POLITE COMPANY

POLITE COMPANY

Written by

Kerry Ann Burke

Copyright (c) 2026
Adapted from screenplay by the author

FIRST DRAFT - v.1.1 (12 August 2026)

kerry.ann.burke.screenwriter@gmail.com
+353 089 218 0307

PRODUCTION NOTES

For consistency, the characters are identified throughout the script as KELLY and MARTIN.

In dialogue, other characters may refer to them by their birth names, KEVIN and MOIRA, respectively.

The stage has a rear-projection screen used for backdrops, projected text, video, and simple visual effects.

MAJOR CHARACTERS

- KELLY O'CONNELL: (Kevin O'Connell) - a middle-age, late-blooming trans woman and stand-up comedian.

- KIERAN: Host of the El Gibbity Comedy Club, an "elder gay" who lived through the 80s. Gives Kelly support in telling her story.

- MARTIN O'CONNELL: (Moira O'Connell) - Kelly's younger brother, a trans man who realized they were trans 20 years ago.

- COLLEEN O'CONNELL: Kelly and Martin's mother.

- RORY O'CONNELL: Kelly and Martin's father.

COMBINED ROLES

FAKE KIERAN / LAIKA:

- FAKE KIERAN: An actor who has been cast in the role of "Kieran" in Kelly's memories, only for the real Kieran to insist, dramatically, that he plays himself. He is "recast" as Laika.

- LAIKA: Rory's pet dog, a Siberian Husky.

MEGAN / REBECCA / ELLIE / MOTHER SUPERIOR:

- MEGAN: Colleen's younger sister and Kelly and Martin's aunt. Nearly 70 years old.

- REBECCA: A teenager. Jewish, lesbian, Kelly's unrequited teenage crush, and later, Martin's girlfriend.

- ELLIE: Kelly's coworker. Punk rock aethetic. Feminist.

- MOTHER SUPERIOR: A Catholic nun.

SHANE / Dr. HOLLADAY / NIGEL:

- SHANE: Colleen's older brother and Kelly and Martin's uncle. 80 years old. Age-related cognitive decline.

- Dr. HOLLADAY: A child psychologist.

- NIGEL: Kelly's British boss.

DECLAN / TEACHER:

- DECLAN: Rory's nephew and Kelly and Martin's cousin.

- TEACHER: A schoolteacher.

SAMANTHA / MARTHA / MAUREEN:

- SAMANTHA: Kelly's coworker. Feminine aethetic. Also a feminist but not nearly as into it as Ellie.

- MARTHA: Rory's friend & operator of a coffee kiosk at Colonial Park

- MAUREEN: Declan's Girlfriend.

FATHER PATRICK / HOST / BULLY:

- HOST: A host of a rival comedy club.

- A BULLY: A school bully.

- FATHER PATRICK: An intimidating Catholic priest.

ACT I: THE EGG

IN DARKNESS

A mechanical voice from off stage.

MOBILE PHONE (O.S.)
You have -- three -- new messages. Message One.

SFX: Beep.

MARTIN (V.O.)
Hey, sis, I'm calling to check on you after that whole... thing... at Thanksgiving. Maybe come spend New Year's with Greta and me? Dad says they've been trying to reach you. Call me.

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
Message two.

SFX: Beep

MEGAN (V.O.)
Hey, Toots, hear you're safe and back in London. Met a guy through work. He's my age. He's nice, he's kind, he's charming.
(beat)
Okay, he's a priest. But I can work with that. Better than Greg, anyway.
(beat)
Your mom's not taking things well. Call her if you can. Have fun in London, kiddo. Knock 'em dead.

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
Message three.

SFX: Beep

COLLEEN (V.O.)
Hey, Kelly. This is your mom. I just wanted to--

SFX: Beep

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
Press 1 if you would like to delete this message. Press 2 if you would like to listen to this message later.

SFX: Beep

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
Please press 1 again to confirm you would like to delete this message. Press 2 to cancel and listen to this message later.

Silence.

SFX: Beep

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
Message saved.

A1 S1: THE GREEN ROOM

LIGHTS UP

A comedian's green room, complete with mirror and chair. A UK flag and "Keep Calm and Carry On" poster. LGBTQ+ and Trans pride flags. Tinsel and fairy lights.

"DECEMBER 2022" flashes for a few seconds onto the rear projection.

A middle-aged trans woman, KELLY enters. She looks male at first glance -- and at second and third. She carries a backpack.

She's wearing a pair of loose fitting grey sweatpants and a zippered grey winter coat. A bit of a pink dress peeks out from the coat.

Kelly has an American accent.

She looks around, casually, then takes off the winter coat and the sweatpants, revealing she's wearing a feminine, floral pink dress. Then she heads to the mirror, and rifles through the backpack.

KELLY
Right. Okay. It's... moisturiser, then primer, then foundation...? No. Hold on. I'm missing a step. Aw, fuzznuggets.

She pulls out a small notepad from the backpack.

KELLY
Moisturizer, primer, *concealer*, foundation. Right.

A knock at the door. It's KIERAN (70s, Scot, theatrical). He's wearing a black vest with various gay pride patches on it.

He's leaning against a mic stand with a microphone on it, looking at some papers he's printed out. He looks worried.

KIERAN
Kelly?

KELLY
Kieran. Hey.

KIERAN
I saw the new material you sent over.

KELLY
Yeah, what did you think?

Kieran frowns, paternally.

KIERAN
(Concerned)
Kelly. Forget the act. *Are you alright?*

KELLY
No. Of course not. But I need this. What happened at home, over Thanksgiving? I need to... get it all out. And that means I need to tell my story. Tell it my way.

KIERAN
Your way has punchlines every thirty seconds.

He gestures to the papers.

KIERAN
I mean, I'm a fan of dark comedy, but Jesus Christ, this isn't material, it's an open wound.

KELLY
Yeah. But... it's an open wound that won't heal if I just... keep this in.

KIERAN
You sure?

KELLY
Kieran. I *need* to do this.

KIERAN
You're sure you're okay turning your pain into bits?

KELLY
Well, way I see it, I've got two choices. Option one: I can laugh. Option two: I can scream.

Kieran hesitates, then slowly, a single nod.

KIERAN
I understand.
(Beat.)
Though... have you tried whisky? That's a viable third option.

KELLY
Worth a shot. Ba-dum-tish!

Kieran groans.

KIERAN
Look, I get you feel you have to do this. But I don't want you to think you have to do this alone. I'll be your backup, okay? If you let me?

KELLY
(touched)
Kieran. I'd be honoured. It... helps knowing you've got my back. For real.

Kieran just smiles and nods.

He grabs a wireless microphone on a stand over on stage left.

He places it in the middle of the stage. Then taps the mic a couple of times.

KIERAN
Check one. Check two.

Kelly puts on the final touches of her makeup, then stands, waiting patiently for her cue.

Satisfied the mic works, Kieran addresses the audience directly, an experienced comedy host.

<u>A1 S2: THE STAGE</u>

The backdrop fades from the green room to a stand-up comedy brick wall for the "El Gibbity Comedy Club, London."

KIERAN
Good evening folks! Thank you all for coming out here to the King of Stars and the El Gibbity Comedy Club on this cold December evening. Tonight's a special treat, one of my favourite comedians, always a pleasure to have her, and one of my good friends. Please, all of you, give a warm welcome to Kelly O'Connell.

Kelly heads towards the mic. Kieran hands it over with a dramatic flourish.

Throughout the play, Kieran will be grabbing and placing props, acting like a stagehand. (Kieran is helping Kelly tell her story.)

NOTE: Whenever Kelly is holding the microphone, she is addressing the audience. During that time, there is a strong spotlight on her.

She'll hand the microphone to Kieran when we head into memory/testimony, and take it back when she addresses the audio again.

When Kelly gets the mic, she grabs and places the stand behind her. It's easy. Practiced. And her smile is genuine.

KELLY
Hello everyone! So... let's just get this out of the way.

She gestures to herself.

KELLY
Yes. As you can plainly tell just by looking, yes. I am... American. So, I know some of you might have some questions. I'd be happy to answer them, after the show. Just, uh, asking about the genitals? That's off limits. Asking a trans woman about her genitals is like asking the Queen about... her genitals. That's between her and the Jubilee Vajazzler.

So... I just came out to my parents a couple of weeks ago. Didn't go well. The pain is still fresh. Which is why it's perfect... for stand-up material.

Eight months ago, my pronouns suddenly became "she" and "her." And just as suddenly, my adjectives became "overwhelmed" and "bewildered."

You don't see many people coming out as trans at the age of 43. Mostly because it's *exhausting*. I had to organize and throw my own gender reveal party. It wrapped up at ten-thirty because most of my friends had acid reflux. The reveal was when we opened up the Pepto Bismol.

She acts out opening the bottle.

KELLY
Pink! It's a bouncing baby ulcer!

Kieran comes out with a blue t-shirt, which Kelly slips over her pink dress as she talks.

KELLY
So. Forty three years. That's a long time to get your gender wrong. And, I wanted to talk a bit about that. About... how someone can be *so wrong* for *so long* and not have a clue. But it requires me to take you on a bit of a mental journey.

Kelly hands the mic back to Kieran as she heads to center stage.

A1 S3: O'CONNELL HOME

The rear projection shows a teenage "boy's" room. Kieran brings out a chair, and places a Nintendo Zapper gun onto the chair.

"SEPTEMBER 1992" flashes for a few seconds onto the rear projection.

Kelly sits down, grabs the gun, and immediately slumps, a child in deep despair.

Duck Hunt plays on the projection.

Kelly, not really caring, points the gun out to the audience and fires. On screen: Kelly nabs two ducks with three shots.

She *deeply* sighs, and rolls her eyes.

In the next round of *Duck Hunt*, Kelly sticks the barrel of the zapper gun in her mouth. She pulls the trigger three times.

Then hangs her head.

The *Duck Hunt* dog laughs.

Colleen calls from the living room.

COLLEEN
Kevin. If you're not dressed yet, get dressed. You've got CCD in a half hour, and if you show up late, the nuns will make you wear a wimple.

Kelly gets up. The background changes to the family living room. There, COLLEEN, Kelly's Irish-American mother, and MARTIN, Kelly's brother (though she identifies as Moira, she/her, here) arrives.

Much like Kelly wears the t-shirt over her dress, Moira wears a pink t-shirt and skirt over a blue dress shirt and jeans.

KELLY
Why a wimple?

COLLEEN
Being late is a bad habit. A wimple is a good habit. Ba-dum-tish!

Kelly and Martin both groan. Colleen is pleased with herself.

COLLEEN
Look, Kelly, before I drop you off... I know things are... difficult for you, but could you please... try not to give the nuns a hard time again? I don't want to get another phone call telling me I need to pick you up early.

Kelly hangs her head.

KELLY
Okay.

COLLEEN
Alright. Let's go. Come along, Moira.

Kelly, Colleen, and Moira exit, stage right.

A few moments.

Then Colleen and Moira both head back in from stage right. Colleen hangs up her purse. Martin heads over to Kelly's

room, (projected on the back screen) sneaking around.

The phone in the living room rings. While the call plays, Martin grabs an unopened package of boy's underwear from Kelly's drawer, stuffing it under his dress.

NUN (V.O)
Hello, Mrs. O'Connell? This is Sister Mary Dolorosa over at Our Lady of Perpetual Help. There was another... incident... with Kevin. Can you come pick him up?

Colleen sighs. Takes a deep breath. Then she picks up her purse.

COLLEEN
(calling)
Moira! Come back, we need to go and pick up your brother.

Martin is startled. He gasps, then, he is relieved.

MARTIN
That's gotta be a new record.

A1 S4: MOTHER SUPERIOR'S OFFICE.

Back screen: Mother Superior's Office.

Kevin is seated guiltily on a chair. The Mother Superior, wearing a wimple, is busy with paperwork on a desk.

Martin meanders, curious about what's under the wimple.

Colleen sits next to Kelly, exasperated.

COLLEEN
What was it this time?

KELLY
I told them I couldn't do confirmation.

COLLEEN
Kevin. The whole point of CCD is to get you *ready* for confirmation.

KELLY
I know. Sister Mary Dolorosa pointed that out as well. I tried to explain... I can't do it. I can't confirm I believe in God, if I don't actually *believe* in God.

COLLEEN
Kevin...

KELLY
No, no, I've thought about this. Right. So... it's not that I believe there is *no* God, okay? It's just, I mean, I don't feel it. I just can't... have faith. And there's not much evidence for being a God, right? If anything, it's the opposite. I mean, Grannie died. Kids at school hate me. I'm failing Lions-Quest.

COLLEEN
Lions-Quest?

KELLY
It's a self-esteem class. They *literally* grade me on how wrong I feel. How would you feel, if you were being *graded* on how you *feel*, and told you were *failing?* No God would allow that.

Martin tries to sneak up on Mother Superior, to see if he can get a peek under the wimple.

COLLEEN
Can't you just go along with it? For now?

KELLY
I thought about it. I did. But I can't. Confirmation is *swearing to God* that I believe. If there's no God... well, then it's just theatre. If there *is* a God, though, and I say I believe when I *don't?* It's *perjury*. Damned if I do, and damned if I don't. Literally. Catechism-22.

Colleen frowns, closes her eyes, places her hand against her temple, and rubs it. A stress headache.

COLLEEN
You rehearsed that, didn't you?

A flicker of a smirk on Kelly's face.

KELLY
A little.

COLLEEN
Kevin, I don't need you to become St. Augustine! I just need you to stop getting thrown out of CCD.

KELLY
I know. I know... I'm too (air quotes) "disruptive."

COLLEEN
Disruptive? Back in my day, the nuns would have made you drink *hemlock*.

Just as Martin is about to make his move, the Mother Superior looks up from the desk.

MOTHER SUPERIOR
That's not true. (Beat.) Not since Vatican II.

A1 S5: O'CONNELL HOME

Kieran hands Kelly the mic. The spotlight returns.

KELLY
(to audience)
I was what they called a 'gifted kid.' Which primarily meant adults became visibly annoyed when I was right. As for my parents? Well... they knew something was wrong. I was clearly depressed. But they figured I was just too *smart* to be happy.
(act-out)
"There's nothing queer about our son! He's just... a *philosopher!*"

Kelly sits down at a table, playing Monopoly with Martin.

KELLY
(to audience)
Both Martin and I were gifted... but we were completely different kinds of gifted.

Kelly picks up the dice, rolls, and moves a thimble. She looks at a dot-matrix printed sheet of paper.

KELLY
(to audience)
See, I was the *smart* one. When I played monopoly, I printed out amortization tables for each of the properties to maximize the return on investment. Martin, on the other hand--

Kelly tilts the table towards the audience. Underneath it, Monopoly money of all colors is tacked onto the underside.

KELLY
(to audience)
Martin was the *clever* one. He was hiding monopoly money so well, my parents still occasionally find bills hidden around the house to this day.

A1 S6: SCHOOL

While Kelly speaks, a school lunchroom set is brought on board - two tables. One with all boys, the other with all girls.

"APRIL 1994" flashes on the screen.

KELLY
(to audience)
Of course, being smart didn't help me much at school. Which, is ironic, because... you'd think it'd be the *one place* it would, right?

A school bell rings.

Kelly hands the mic back to Kieran.

Kelly takes a seat at the boys table, drinking school-issued milk. He has a male FRIEND across the table from him.

A girl, REBECCA, wearing a Star of David pendant, passes by, crossing in front of Kelly and the Audience.

REBECCA
Hey, Kevin.

Kelly is startled, nearly choking on the milk. Rebecca smiles, snorts, and sits down at the girls' table, her back to Kelly.

FRIEND
You really have a thing for Rebecca, don't you?

KELLY
I'll say. I mean, I'd cut both my balls off just to see her smile.

Rebecca reacts to this, nonplussed but amused, peeking back at Kelly. Kelly doesn't

notice. The friend, however, blinks in shock.

FRIEND
Kevin. (drawn out.) Why... is that... your plan... "A"?

KELLY
What, you think I should start with flowers?

FRIEND
I think you should give up. You know she's lesbian, right?

KELLY
No she's not. (a beat.) She's *Jewish*.

Rebecca, who has heard all this, and thinks it's hilarious, tries, and fails, to keep a straight face.

KELLY
Right. I'm doing this.

Kelly turns around.

KELLY
Hey, uh, Rebecca?

Rebecca turns around, trying to keep from laughing, still.

KELLY
I was wondering if you would be interested in maybe seeing a movie. You know. If you're free.

Rebecca gives Kelly an incredulous, but amused look. Dead, awkward silence.

KELLY
I mean, it doesn't *have* to be a movie. It could be--

REBECCA
Kevin. Stop. You're a good friend, and a sweet guy. But us dating? That would be a terrible idea.

KELLY
How so?

REBECCA
You're not my type.

KELLY
What-- what is your type?

REBECCA
Women.

Another awkward silence.

KELLY
I mean, that's my type too! We have *so much* in common! How's Saturday?

FRIEND
Wow. He doubled down.

Rebecca tilts her head, thinking about it.

REBECCA
We can see a movie, but only if we go as friends.

KELLY
Okay!

REBECCA
This will end badly. You know that, right?

KELLY
I mean, what doesn't?

A1 S7: MOVIE THEATRE

Kelly and Rebecca stand up, and the scene shifts to a movie theatre in the background. Kelly and Rebecca sit in the theatre seats. The house lights are on and the movie hasn't started.

REBECCA
Honestly, Kevin? You're really sweet. But I should be honest with you. I mostly agreed to do this because Dad thinks the only reason I like girls is because I haven't tried dating guys. This... will keep him off my back for a while.

Kelly nods. She doesn't like it, but she understands perfectly.

KELLY (15)
I know the feeling.

REBECCA
You do?

KELLY (15)
Yeah. Mom's the same way with me about Catholicism. Says that it might make me less depressed if I found faith.
(MORE)

KELLY (15) (cont'd)
Maybe I can get her off my back if I said you had me interested in converting.

REBECCA
To Judaism?

KELLY (15)
Unless there's a way to convert to lesbianism.
Rebecca snort-laughs.

REBECCA
Mom thinks that it's a phase. That I'll grow out of it in college. Like she did.
She smiles at Kelly.

REBECCA
Honestly? You're going to be a really good boyfriend to someone someday.

Kelly sadly smiles.

KELLY (15)
Just not today.

REBECCA
C'mon. Movie's about to start.

Kieran enters and hands the microphone to Kelly.

KELLY
(to audience)
1994 was a great year for movies. That was the year P*ulp Fiction* came out. It was the year the S*hawshank Redemption* came out. *Forrest Gump*. *Speed*. *Interview with the Vampire*. All classics. What did I take Rebecca to see?

On the screen: *Ed Wood*.

Kelly hands the mic back to Kieran.

WEISS (ON-SCREEN)
Well screw you! (hangs up phone) Hi, can I help ya?

ED WOOD (ON-SCREEN)
Yes, I'm Ed Wood. I'm here about directing the Christine Jorgensen picture.

KELLY
Christine *who?*

A1 S8: LIBRARY

Kelly gets up, heads to a library. (Rebecca exits.)

There, an old card catalogue waits for her. She flips through it.

Projected on the wall behind her: the entries she finds. It scrolls down. Slowly.

JORGENSEN, CHRISTINE

See:
TRANSSEXUALISM

See also:
SEX REASSIGNMENT
SEXUAL PERVERSIONS

She moves to the "T" drawer.

TRANSSEXUALISM

306.768

Bullough, Vern.
Sexual Variance in Society and History

Green, Richard.
The "Sissy Boy Syndrome"

Various periodicals

Kelly gets the books. Sits at a desk. Reads. Turns page. Reads. Turns page.

The stage lighting slowly changes. Turns page. The library around her gets darker.

Turns page. Eventually Kelly looks up.

Night.

Kieran enters and hands the microphone to Kelly.

KELLY
(to audience)
In hindsight, this should have been a clue. Not only to my gender identity, but also to my autism. But it was 1994. Back then, they just called it "being a nerd."

Kelly passes the mic back to Kieran.

A1 S9: CLASSROOM

Kelly is still sitting at the desk with the books, but the classroom - via the screen - has arrived around her.

SFX: A school bell. The lights change to day.

While she's still writing, students simply arrive around her, carrying desks.

Rebecca sits at the next desk over. Next to Rebecca, another girl, visibly lesbian. Rebecca is smitten, smiling, and tucking her hair back. The lesbian smiles and does double-finger guns.

Kelly barely notices. She's writing in her own notebook, talking under her breath.

KELLY
(to self)
Right, right... so... Denmark 1952. Was this a one-time thing, or did other people do it in the forty years since? Was it a big deal at the time? Maybe I should get Mom to drive me to the college library on the weekend, they might have more stuff there.

A teacher enters. They're visibly shaken. Kelly pays no attention, focused on her notebook.

TEACHER
Hello everyone. Well... uh, I can tell you we're not doing geometry today. I know a lot of you are... fans of Nirvana, and you've probably heard the news about Kurt Cobain.

A few kids look down. Kelly looks up briefly, then goes back

to her notebook, only half paying attention, writing furiously.

TEACHER
So, when something like this happens, we... like to check in with everyone. See how everyone is doing. Something like this... can really affect people.

Kelly writes furiously, tongue out in concentration.

TEACHER
So, has anyone here ever had thoughts about suicide?

Without looking up from her doodling and note-taking, Kelly raises her hand. It's automatic. Matter-of-fact.

The room goes silent.

TEACHER
Kevin?

Kelly finally looks up. She looks around the room. No other hands are up. Everyone is staring.

TEACHER
You've been thinking about--

KELLY
Yeah.
(sincere)
Doesn't everybody?

Kelly turns to look at Rebecca.

Rebecca shakes her head, slowly.

Kelly looks around at the rest of the class. They're all trying to look away.

She sits in the awkwardness.

Kelly hangs her head, but keeps her hand up.

KELLY
Ah beans.

A1 S10: SCHOOL HALLWAY

SFX: School Bell.

Students cart their desks out. Lockers come in.

Kelly gets up, goes to her locker, but doesn't open it yet.

Rebecca walks by with the lesbian and a group of other girls. Kelly waves.

KELLY

Hey Rebecca...

Rebecca is embarrassed to know Kelly. She literally shields her face from Kelly with her hand.

Kelly's shoulders slump. She takes a moment to ground herself.

Finally, she opens her locker.

Inside the locker: A noose. Hanging from the hooks on the top of the locker. She stares just long enough for it to register with her (and the audience)

Then, she SLAMS the locker shut.

From the other direction, a BULLY and a group of boys pass by.

BULLY

Hey, Buckshot!

The bullies keep walking, laughing at Kelly.

Silence.

Kieran brings a bin over to Kelly, while Rory and Colleen start bringing in two reclining chairs, and a couch.

Kelly takes the noose out of the locker, and places it in the bin. Kieran wheels the bin offstage.

A1 S11: O'CONNELL HOME

Colleen and Rory sit on the reclining chairs. Rory is reading a newspaper. Colleen is doing a crossword puzzle.

Kelly then walks slowly over to the couch. She falls face down onto it.

Doesn't move for a few seconds.

Then:

Kelly groans.

COLLEEN
Rough day, kiddo?

KELLY
Aren't they all?

COLLEEN
What happened?

KELLY
Well, the kids have started calling me "buckshot." Someone broke into my locker and left a noose in there.

COLLEEN
What?

Rory looks up, puts his newspaper away. Colleen does the same with her crossword.

RORY
Did you tell anyone at school? A teacher?

KELLY
Of course not. What's a teacher going to do? Best case, nothing happens. Worst case, they'll think I put it in there myself.

RORY
Why would they think you made a death threat to *yourself?*

KELLY
Well, it turns out, most kids don't think about death as often as I do. Or... at all, really.

Colleen and Rory look at each other, they don't quite know how to respond.

COLLEEN
Maybe it's just a prank? Maybe they didn't realize how much it would hurt. You know. Kids will be kids.

Kelly curls up into the fetal position.

RORY
Ah, don't worry about it. They just want to see you react. Don't react, and they'll just get bored and leave you alone. Just, act... normal for a while. Trust me. It'll all blow over.

Rory picks up the newspaper again. After a moment, Colleen picks up the crossword.

A moment.

Then, Kelly sobs.

Colleen turns to Kelly, still curled, facing the sofa, crying.

Colleen looks over to Rory, who is still reading the newspaper. She clears her throat.

Rory turns. Colleen nudges with her head over to Kelly.

RORY
Uh, Kevin, you know, uh, how would you feel if we... got you to talk to a psychologist for a bit?

Kelly stops sobbing. She looks up.

KELLY
(confused)
Like Dr. Ruth?

COLLEEN
Uh. No. More like... *Frasier*. But, for kids.

Kelly shrugs.

<u>A1 S12: PSYCHOLOGIST OFFICE</u>

Kelly is still curled up in the fetal position on the couch, unmoving, as the backdrop changes to a psychologist's office.

One of the chairs is dragged away by Rory and Colleen, as Dr. HOLLADAY comes in, mid-40s, grey three-piece suit.

Kelly finally rolls over, onto her back.

KELLY
So, Doctor Holladay... that's the whole thing. And before you ask, I don't know why I'm miserable. It's like... there's something missing.

Holladay scribbles notes, nodding.

KELLY
Maybe it's love? I don't know. But that feels like... the wrong answer to the wrong question.

HOLLADAY
I don't know. Love seems to work for a heck of a lot of people. Why do you mention it?

Kelly clutches a pillow to her chest, and sits up.

KELLY
There's this girl at school.

Holiday smirks.

HOLLADAY
What's her name?

KELLY
Rebecca. She's so pretty. And she knows exactly who she is, you know? Smart, too. I've got a huge crush, but, uh, it's completely unrequited.

HOLLADAY
Unrequited?

KELLY
It means she doesn't like me back.

HOLLADAY
Yes, Kevin, I know what unrequited means. I'm actually surprised *you* know what unrequited means.

KELLY
I'm a nerd.

HOLLADAY
Ah. That explains it. But this Rebecca.

KELLY
I mean, it'd never work out anyway. She's a lesbian.

HOLLADAY
That does make it difficult, yes.

Kelly sighs.

KELLY
Doc... do you ever wonder what it's like to be a lesbian?

Holladay looks up.

HOLLADAY
No.
(Beat.)
Do you?

KELLY
I mean, being a lesbian... it seems like... fun?
(Beat.)
Girls seem... comfortable. With each other. They hug a lot. Nobody thinks it's weird. (Beat.) I don't know why, but... I think I'd rather be... like them. Like, if male lesbian was an option, I'd do that.

Holladay studies her.

HOLLADAY
Well, it's not like you can.

Kelly rubs her temples.

KELLY
Well, here's the thing. I was reading about this woman... Christine Jorgensen...

Holladay fumbles his pen at hearing the name.

Kelly notices.

HOLLADAY
(slowly)
Christine... *Jorgensen*.

KELLY
Yeah. Heard of her?

HOLLADAY
Let me stop you right there. Christine Jorgensen was a... *very* unusual case. Extraordinarily uncommon.
(Beat.)
Besides, that's not something you can just... experiment with. You'd have to be absolutely certain. It's not reversible.

Kelly is crestfallen.

HOLLIDAY
(folksy)
It's easier to dig a hole than to build a pole.

Kelly lies back down.

KELLY
Oh.

HOLLADAY
Besides, from what you've said about Rebecca, you certainly don't sound gay.

KELLY
(defeated)
Yeah. (Beat.) Nobody wants that.

A1 S13: O'CONNELL KITCHEN

The couch cleared away and a kitchen table is brought in.

Martin is no longer wearing a pink dress. He's wearing a pink button-down dress shirt and pink necktie. (Men's clothes, but still *pink*.)

(From stage left-to-right) Rory, Martin, Kelly, and Colleen sit. They're eating dinner.

The screen flashes: "MARCH 1997"

COLLEEN
So. Kevin. This came in the mail for you.

Colleen takes out thick, large envelope.

Kelly looks at it with awe.

KELLY
Is that...

COLLEEN
From the college.

RORY
And it's *thick*.

Kelly's nervous. She hesitates opening it.

COLLEEN
Go on.

Kelly tears into it like a kid with a Christmas present. She reads the covering letter.

KELLY
Dear Kevin. Congratulations!

She beams.

KELLY
I am pleased to offer you admission to Raleigh State University as part of the entering class of 1997! This offer is being extended to you because who the heck cares I'll read the rest later! I'm going to college!

COLLEEN
A *good* college!

RORY
An *affordable* college!

The family comes in for a group hug.

Kieran heads over with a blue college sweatshirt.

Kelly takes her blue t-shirt off, tosses it to Kieran, who tosses Kelly the sweatshirt. She puts it on (over the ever-present dress.)

COLLEEN
We're so proud of you! SO proud.

KELLY
Aw, it's not Harvard.

RORY
Thank god for that!

MARTIN
So, you planning on living at home or in the dorms?

RORY
Why would he want to live in the dorms? Here you have free room and board. Free laundry.

COLLEEN
I'm not doing it for you, you know. But at least you don't have to bring quarters to every wash.

KELLY
All true, but there is one major drawback. It's not like I can bring any girls over if I stay here.

MARTIN
Kevin.

Kelly turns to Martin.

MARTIN
I'm not saying this to be mean. But... realistically? What are the chances?

KELLY
Good point. I'll commute.

MARTIN
Though when the time comes, I want to live in the dorms. I want to have girls over.

Rory and Colleen hear that, raise their eyebrows.

COLLEEN
You can have girls over here. It's boys you need to watch out for, Moira.

KELLY
Oh yeah, weren't you telling me that you were dating someone?

Martin looks mortified.

MARTIN
Yeah, uh, I did.

KELLY
Cool. Anyone I know? What's his name?

MARTIN
(long pause)
Rebecca.

Everyone nods, goes back to their meals. A slow burn. Colleen is the first to catch it.

Then Rory.

Kelly takes the longest.

In the background, Kieran takes off his vest-- the one with queer pride patches.

KELLY
Wait a minute. You can't date Rebecca. She's a lesbian.
(Beat.)
She's a lesbian.
(Long beat.)
Oh.

On the "Oh.", Kieran tosses Martin his vest. Martin puts it on over his pink shirt (which is, again, over his suit.)

COLLEEN
(Calming herself.)
Okay. Okay.
(Shocked realization.)
Just... promise me you won't convert. I don't think I could handle it if you convert!

KELLY
I think she already has.

COLLEEN
To *Judaism,* Kevin!

KELLY
Right. I knew that.

COLLEEN
I mean, this is a bit of a shock, but...

RORY
Not *that much* of a shock.

MARTIN
Whoa, whoa. Hold on. Allow me to reassure you.
(Beat.)
I'm not converting. I like bacon too much to even consider it.

Colleen is relieved.

Kelly gets thoughtful. She scootches her chair, audibly, towards Martin.

SKRRRRRRRRRT.

KELLY
So... Moira...

Kelly moves six inches closer.

SKRRRRRRT.

KELLY
Being a lesbian...

MARTIN
Yes...?

KELLY
What's it like?
(Beat.)
Is... is it fun?

MARTIN
Being a lesbian? I think so.
(Beat.)
Being a woman. Not so much.

COLLEEN
Too true. I mean, about being a woman. Cramps are not fun.

MARTIN
Yeah, be thankful you're a guy, Kevin.

Kelly shrugs.

Kieran hands Kelly the microphone again, as the rest of the actors clear away the kitchen table.

KELLY
(to audience)
Now, I didn't show any of the (air quotes) "classic" signs of being trans. My brother, on the other hand, if you haven't already guessed... absolutely textbook. Came out as a lesbian as a teenager. Started wearing boys' clothing. Stole my boxer shorts.
(beat)
And before you ask, no I didn't steal his panties. They wouldn't have fit.
(beat)
I checked.

Kelly hands the mic back to Kieran.

A1 S14: WOMEN'S DORM

A dorm room, with pink cinderblock walls. A student bed. On the desk, a large desktop computer with a old 2002 style CRT.

Production note: This could be a cardboard box that

looks like a computer monitor from the side facing the audience.

The screen flashes: "SEPTEMBER 2002"

Martin heads in with a suitcase.

Kelly crouches behind the computer.

KELLY
Knew it. This is, like, 90% of what I do at the shop. Boot it up?

Martin powers it on. It comes up.

MARTIN
Neat. Thanks.

He sits on the bed, slumping. Kelly works a moment -- then double-takes.

KELLY
Moira, hey--what's up?

Martin shrugs. Kelly sits beside him on the bed.

MARTIN
I'm scared. I didn't think I would be.

KELLY
Living in a women's dorm.
(beat)
As a lesbian.
(beat)
Surrounded by hot, intelligent young women who are just now experiencing their first real moments of independence and freedom.
(beat)
Must be hell.

MARTIN
It is. I don't know why.

Martin stands, shuts the door, returns.

MARTIN
Kevin... can I tell you something? I hate being a girl.
(beat)
I kinda want to... get rid of my breasts. Be a guy. Like that Hilary Swank movie.

Kelly freezes. Finally:

KELLY
(softly)
Can I have 'em?

MARTIN
Kevin...

KELLY
They seem fun.

Martin glares. Kelly softens.

KELLY
Look, Moira... I'm on your side.

She takes Martin's hand.

MARTIN
You don't get it.

KELLY
I said I'm on your side. I didn't say I'd be *good* at it.

A moment, then Martin opens up his luggage. In it, a *blue* dress shirt.

He doesn't put it on yet. He just holds it.

He rests his head on Kelly's shoulder.

MARTIN
Not a word to Mom and Dad.

KELLY
Alright. Your call, Moira.

Martin shrugs, fidgets with the blue shirt. Doesn't put it on yet.

MARTIN
Maybe if I showed them the movie.

<u>A1 S15: O'CONNELL LIVING ROOM</u>

Kelly helps Martin drag the dorm bed off-stage, while Rory and Colleen bring the recliners and the sofa back in.

The scene changes to the living room.

Kelly re-enters. Rory and Colleen are watching television on a CRT. They nod to her as she comes in.

Production note: This could be the other side of the cardboard box - just rotated.

KELLY
So, Moira's all moved in to her dorm.

RORY
That's good.

Kelly sits down on the couch, turns to a CRT television.

KELLY
What's on?

COLLEEN
Silence of the Lambs.

The infamous "Mirror Scene" from *SOTL* plays on the screen. But the audio is bleeped.

BUFFALO BILL
Would you [bleep] me--?
--I'd [bleep] me. I'd [bleep] me hard.

Kelly goes still. A beat.

COLLEEN
It's just not the same when it's on basic cable.

Kelly sinks down into the couch.

The movie pauses on the screen. Buffalo Bill's face.

Kieran hands Kelly the mic.

KELLY
(to audience)
That's what trans stories looked like back then. Trans men got Brandon Teena. I got Buffalo Bill. That movie won five Oscars... then crawled into my childhood and pissed on the furniture.
(beat)
My brother came out as a trans man the next year. I came out to myself... twenty years later.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
Now when my brother calls me "a big dummy," he has objective proof.

Kelly takes one look back at the screen. Shakes her head.

A1 S16: FAST FORWARD

KELLY
(to audience)
I'm just going to quickly fast forward for the next twenty years. You're not missing much. I spent most of it dissociated.
(beat)
But they were good years for Martin.

She walks off to the side, giving Martin centre stage. He's joined by GRETA, a Norwegian woman. They hold hands.

KELLY
(to audience)
He graduated with a B.A. in psychology. Then, a year after graduation, Martin met his wife, Greta, online, and they moved in together.

The screen shows a lovely Scandinavian minimalist home.

KELLY
(to audience)
In Norway. Which goes to show, when you look for love, it's always in the last place you look.
(beat)
Ironically, they met on a *Harry Potter* fan site.
(beat)
It wasn't long after that that Martin... started going by Martin. Since he's been on testosterone, he's just been... happier.

Martin takes off the "queer" vest and hands it back to Kieran, who puts it back on. He also takes off the pink clothing, revealing the blue suit underneath.

KELLY
(to audience)
I remember when Martin got top surgery, I told him that if he was considering bottom surgery, he should put me on the donor list. I was *just that good* a brother. Plus, since we're related, less likely the organ would be rejected. He thought I was kidding.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
I did too.

Kieran comes onstage with luggage.

KELLY
(to audience)
Me, I tried to be happy. I tried *so many ways* to be happy. I moved to Texas to get a graduate degree in Journalism from Central Texas University.

Kieran tosses Kelly a cowboy hat and graduation robe. She puts them on.

KELLY
(to audience)
Then I tried traveling. Wrote a book on comparative politics.

Kieran sticks travel stickers onto the cowboy hat.

KELLY
(to audience)
I ran for Texas State representative.

Kieran hands Kelly an American flag.

KELLY
(to audience)
I even switched careers. Taught myself to code.

Kieran hands Kelly a blue flannel shirt. By the end, Kieran can barely keep up with Kelly's narration.

KELLY
(to audience)
I wasn't failing at life. By every objective measure, I was succeeding. Except in one respect. Everywhere I went, everything I tried. I was still miserable. The point is... I was trying everything -- *anything* -- except for what the problem actually was. And then... whoosh. Twenty years in the blink of an eye. Honestly, dissociation is a better time machine than a DeLorean.
(beat)
Three years ago, I got a tech job here in London. Why London? Because London is the stand-up comedy capital of the world. I did the cliched mid-life crisis thing and finally followed my dreams.
(beat)
Okay, I was naive. But I thought this one... this would finally be it. The change that made me happy.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
I *almost* got it right. *Almost*.

Kelly looks down at herself.

KELLY
(to audience)
But the problem wasn't that I was trans*atlantic*.

Kelly starts shedding the hat, the robe, the stickers, but keeps the blue flannel shirt on.

She hands Kieran back the mic.

A1 S17: OFFICE

We're in an open plan office. Two women with laptops, SAMANTHA on Kelly's left, ELLIE, in punk-rock attire, on Kelly's right. Ellie's laptop is crowded with feminist stickers: ABOLISH THE PAY GAP. WOMEN IN CODE. SMASH THE PATRIARCHY.

ELLIE
Sam.

SAMANTHA
Yeah, Ellie?

ELLIE
I wanted to know if you're coming to the meetup tomorrow. We're doing intro to Python.

Kelly arrives, and places her laptop down at the table, taking a seat.

SAMANTHA
I *do* want to learn Python. Is there a fee?

ELLIE
Nah, but it's nice to order a drink or two from the venue.

KELLY
Are you talking about learning Python? I'm down for that. Where's the meetup.

ELLIE
Ah, no, Kevin. Sorry. It's the monthly Women in STEM meetup.

Kelly sighs.

KELLY
Oh.

SAMANTHA
Otherwise, we'd invite you in a heartbeat.

ELLIE
Yeah, Kevin. You're one of the *good* ones. When the revolution comes, you will be one of the men we spare.

KELLY
Thank you. Good to know.

SAMANTHA
It's just that... women need a space, you know? A place where we don't have to worry about...

KELLY
Oh, no, I absolutely get it. It's one less thing to have to worry about. Guy like me walks into a room and immediately, you have to worry: Am I a threat? Am I a perv?

ELLIE
Are you a Tory?

KELLY
Exactly. It's just easier to have your own... community where you don't have to worry.
(a pause)
I think about what it's like to be a woman a lot.

Ellie nods.

ELLIE
It's not fun.

SAMANTHA
(sotto)
Parts of it are fun.

KELLY
Yeah. Women have it much harder than men do. Especially in tech.

ELLIE
Damn straight.

A pause. Samantha and Ellie go back to their computers.

KELLY
But...

Samantha and Ellie turn back to Kelly. Ellie, in particular, has a frown on her face.

KELLY
...it just seems to me that there's one--
(pause)
Okay. Stop me if I say something stupid or sexist but--

ELLIE
Ah, bup bup buyp. Kevin. Close your eyes.

Kelly does so. Ellie takes a candy bar wrapper off the desk and CRINKLES it close to Kelly's ear.

ELLIE
That... is the sound of thin ice. Cracking.

Kelly opens her eyes.

ELLIE
You've been warned. Go ahead.

KELLY
Right. Well, it just seems to me, you know, that if there's one thing to be learned from feminism, it's that... there's no wrong way to be a woman.

SAMANTHA
Okay. Sure.

KELLY
But there absolutely *is* a wrong way to be a man, you know? Like, we're just... *expected* to do things. Like, even the *bad* things, if we don't do them, we're somehow wrong? I just think... maybe the way my brain works... It'd be easier for *me*, personally, to handle the problems women typically face than it is for me to handle the problems I face as a man. Does that make any sense?

Ellie and Samantha stare blankly at Kelly.

ELLIE
That's the saddest thing you've ever said to me.

SAMANTHA
Kevin, are you okay?

Kelly stays at the desk while Samantha and Ellie exit. NIGEL, a middle manager in a white shirt, comes up, holding coffee.

NIGEL
Kevin. How are you doing?

KELLY
Hey, Nigel. Fine, I guess. And you?

NIGEL
Oh, no, I actually meant to check on how you were feeling, not just... make small talk.

KELLY
Oh. That's refreshing. Normally I mistake it the other way around and infodump my anxieties at the slightest provocation.

NIGEL
Kevin, people are worried about you.

Kelly isn't sure how to react to that.

KELLY
That's... nice.

NIGEL
You haven't been yourself lately.

A beat.

KELLY
I don't think that's the problem.

NIGEL
Well, whatever it is, don't try to carry it alone. Okay?
(beat)
We have an employee assistance programme. Have you considered seeing a professional?

KELLY
A dominatrix?

Horrified realization as to what she just said.

KELLY
You meant a *therapist*.
(beat)
Ah fluffernutter.

Nigel laughs.

NIGEL
Is that part of your stand-up act?

KELLY
It is now.

NIGEL
That's this Thursday?

KELLY
Yeah. Student showcase, so I can't guarantee it'll be any good.

NIGEL
I'll be there if I can. Look, just know, mental health is important to us here. Take some time to take care of yourself, if you need it.

A beat.

NIGEL
After the product launch, obviously.

KELLY
I'll be sure to schedule my mental health around the deliverables.

NIGEL
Good man.

A1 S18: STAND UP BOMBING

The scene shifts to a stand-up venue. It's not the same one that Kieran hosts.

Kieran comes by, and offers the mic. A HOST walks in, and also offers another mic - distinctive from the one Kieran usually gives her.

Kelly looks between the two confused.

Kieran leans over, looks at the other host with disdain, scowling.

Kelly notices, then takes the mic from Kieran.

KELLY
(to audience)
Excuse us a quick moment.

Kelly takes Kieran aside and upstage.

KELLY
Kieran, I'm kind of in the middle of something here.

KIERAN
I'm pretty sure doing a stand-up act in two different places at the same time is against the laws of physics. And it's unprofessional!

Kelly and Kieran look back to the host.

KELLY
(to Kieran)
No, no, this... this is a memory. Of an earlier stand-up act I did. This happened before I even met you. When I was still going by Kevin.

KIERAN
Well, can you make that clearer? I'm getting a little confused.

KELLY
(to Kieran)
I'll try.

Kelly looks back to the screen. It flashes "MARCH 2022" Then it flashes "NINE MONTHS AGO"

KIERAN
Ah. Yeah. That'll do it.

KELLY
We good?

KIERAN
We're good.

Kelly nods and hands Kieran's mic back to Kieran. She then heads to center stage.

HOST
Starting off our student showcase, welcome to the stage, Kevin O'Connell!

Kelly takes the Host's mic, and then in high energy, starts working up the crowd.

KELLY
(to audience)
Are you feeling good tonight?

She points the mic to the audience. (Hopefully, they cheer).

KELLY
Let me hear it!

(Hopefully they cheer louder.)

KELLY
I'm here to talk about depression.

Immediately, Kelly's shoulders slump.

She hangs her head. Takes a deep sigh.

KELLY
So, I have what doctors call 'dysthymia.' Sounds like the name of an amusement park.
(beat)
The rides are no fun.
(beat)
There's the saddy-go-round.
(beat)
The life is unferris-wheel.
(beat)
There's a hall of mirrors, but the mirrors are normal. It's me that's the freakshow.

Kieran winces. Big oof.

A1 S19: POST STAND UP BOMBING PUB

Kelly hands the mic back to the host. She heads over to the bar in the pub. An AUDIENCE MEMBER comes up to her.

AUDIENCE MEMBER
Hey. Kevin, right?

KELLY
Yeah.

AUDIENCE MEMBER
I saw your set. I, uh--just wanted to say hi.

KELLY
Really? You thought it was funny?

The audience member shifts, uncomfortable.

AUDIENCE MEMBER
I thought... it was brave, you know.
(beat)
I mean--if you ever need to, like... talk to someone...

The audience member takes out a business card and hands it to her.

Kelly looks at it.

KELLY
This is a number for the Samaritans.

AUDIENCE MEMBER
Yeah. Just... you know, if you need to...

Kelly takes out her wallet.
Pulls out seven identical cards.

KELLY
It's alright. I've got seven just like it. This'll make number eight.
(beat)
I collect ten and I get a free pair of grippy socks.

A1 S20: BEDROOM DOOMSCROLL

Kelly heads home. There's a bed. It's got piles of clothes on it. She doesn't bother moving the piles of clothing before laying down on it, sighing.

She sits up. Grabs a laptop. Starts doomscrolling.

We see what she's doomscrolling on the screen.

A headline: Russia Invades Ukraine.

Next.

A YouTube video: Porch Pirates Get Glitter Bombed.

Next.

A *Real Life Comics* Strip.

www.reallifecomics.com/index.php?comic=june-29-2020

Panel 1

Greg is sitting at his computer, puttering around doing nothing.

Panel 2

Post shows up on screen: "If you're under the assumption that you're a

cis guy but have always dreamed of being a girl, and the only reason you haven't transitioned is because you're afraid you'll be an "ugly" girl: That's dysphoria. You're literally a trans girl already, hon."

Kelly sits up suddenly. Freaked out.

Panel 3

Greg looks freaked out.

Kelly is now really freaked out.

Panel 4

Greg looks SUPER freaked out.

Kelly closes the laptop. Eyes wide open.

KELLY
(slowly)
Oh, dip!

Kelly covers her face with the pillow and lies back down on the bed.

LIGHTS DOWN

Silence.

Then:

Kelly lets out a MUFFLED SCREAM.

END OF ACT I

ACT II: THE CHICK

LIGHTS UP

A2 S1: MARTIN'S HOUSE/KELLY'S FLAT

Martin is sitting down, drinking coffee, in a house of Scandanavian minimalist decor. Comfortable, relaxing with a book. He's taken off the suit jacket and put on a warm blue sweater over his dress shirt and tie.

A bookshelf nearby, with books.

SFX: Phone RINGS

He takes his phone out of his pocket.

MARTIN
Ja, det er Martin?

The screen splits, wiping in from the right. Kelly's bedroom.

Kelly enters, pacing, nervous. covered herself in a blue blanket, wrapped around her for comfort.

KELLY
Hey Martin. It's Kevin... your brother.

She winces.

MARTIN
Yes, Kevin, I know who you are.

KELLY
(sotto)
Glad one of us does... listen, uh, is this a good time for a big talk? I understand if you're busy... what do Norwegians do for fun? Solve murders?

MARTIN
What?

KELLY
I don't know much about Scandanavia. I'm mostly going off of Netflix dramas.

Martin groans, then gets serious.

MARTIN
You sound nervous. More than usual, I mean. Did something happen?

KELLY
Kinda? I think I might be an egg.

Kelly winces again as she says it.

Martin slow blinks. Concerned. Confused. Stands up.

A pause.

MARTIN
You think... you might be an *egg*?

KELLY
I only realized it yesterday. I mean, it makes sense. I've been talking to people on the internet, they say I'm an egg, that I talk like an egg and think like an egg and--

MARTIN
Kevin. Bro. Slow down.

KELLY
Right. Well. Before I made any big decisions, I wanted to call you. Since you were an egg once.

Martin squints, dubiously.

MARTIN
I was an *egg*?

KELLY
Yeah.

Another, longer pause.

MARTIN
When you say "egg"... what do you mean?

KELLY
You know... egg. I just realized... I might be transgender too.

Martin stills.

MARTIN
Okay. So *not a literal egg*.

He's relieved.

KELLY
You didn't think...

MARTIN
With you, I can never tell.

He then stops. Scowls.

MARTIN
Wait a second.
(beat)
Are you *stealing my bit?*

KELLY
...I don't... think so?

MARTIN
Get on a video call. I want to look in your eyes when you say that.

Kieran enters carrying a large cardboard video-call frame and hands it to Martin. Martin holds it around himself. He is now on Kelly's laptop.

Whenever Martin appears by video call, he holds the frame around himself.

Kelly and Martin just stare at each other for a bit.

MARTIN
Right... Okay.
(processing)
Yeah.

KELLY
So... what do I do?

MARTIN
I don't know, Kevin. This is... a lot.
(pause)
Don't... tell Mom and Dad right away. I don't know how they'd react.

A long beat.

KELLY
"Here we go again?"

Martin shoots Kelly a look.

MARTIN
Are you *sure, sure?*

KELLY
No. How do I get sure-sure?

MARTIN
You could try hormone replacement therapy.

KELLY
I looked it up. Seeing someone at the gender clinic here in the UK takes somewhere between four years and... the heat death of the universe. If I get on the waiting list today I might be able to bequeath my position in the queue to my future granddaughter.

MARTIN
Maybe you could do grey-market?

KELLY
Is that safe?

Martin shrugs.

MARTIN
I don’t know. Some people do it.
(shrug)
If it doesn't feel right, you can stop.

Kelly pulls the duvet tighter.

KELLY
But what if it *does?* Feel right, I mean.

MARTIN
Then maybe the depression lifts. More energy. Softer skin. You'll probably smell better. Bald spot could make a comeback.

KELLY
Really?

MARTIN
Yeah.
(soft, sincere)
But that's only in the worst case scenario. You might not actually be trans. You could just be having a mental breakdown.

KELLY
Well... let's keep our fingers crossed.

A2 S2: SHOPPING MONTAGE

A shopping mall.

Kelly removes the duvet, handing it to Kieran. Kieran brings by a

blue shirt in a camouflage pattern, and a shopping bag.

Kelly looks at it. Then back to Kieran. Then back at the camo shirt.

Kieran shrugs and smiles.

Kelly shrugs and puts it on.

Stagehands roll out a makeup display. Kelly picks up some lipstick.

The CHEMIST notices Kelly examining the lipstick. He looks with confusion.

KELLY
(to Chemist)
Niece's birthday.

The Chemist nods, then Kelly puts the makeup in the bag.

The stagehands then bring out a clothing rack, with all pink, feminine clothing.

Kelly picks out a pink dress from the rack. It's exactly like the one she's wearing underneath her camo.

She holds it up to her body, evaluating it.

A PATRON looks at Kelly with suspicion.

KELLY
(to Patron)
I'm a pantomime dame. It's for a panto show.

KIERAN
(Panto)
Oh, no it's not!

The audience might join in. If they do, Kelly reacts accordingly: grateful if they support her excuse ("Oh yes it is!"), mortified if they side with Kieran ("Oh no it's not!").

KELLY
(Panto)
Oh, yes it is!

KIERAN
(Panto)
Oh, no it's not!

KELLY
(to audience, pleading)
Please. Just go along with it.
(beat)
I'm having an emotional crisis.

Kelly puts the dress in the bag.

Stagehands roll out a shoe display with heels.

Kelly takes off her shoes, tries the heels on.

A CURIOUS BOY wanders in from offstage. Staring.

Kelly stares back.

KELLY
For reaching tall shelves.

The boy gasps.

CURIOUS BOY
That's brilliant!

The boy starts to run off. Kelly is relieved. But then:

CURIOUS BOY
Mum! Can I get heels?

Kelly's eyes fly open in sudden horror. (Abort! Abort!) She quickly puts the shoes in the bag, slips her other shoes back on, and sprints offstage.

<u>A2 S3: KELLY'S FLAT</u>

Back in Kelly's flat, she comes in with her bag, then sets it down.

SFX: DOORBELL.

Kieran, wearing a delivery driver's uniform, comes in with an agressively boring, blank cardboard box, handing it off to Kelly.

She takes it to centre stage. Opens it.

Oestrogen patches.

She looks left and right. Guiltily. Furtively.

She takes off the camo shirt.

Then... she hikes up her dress... and places an estrogen patch on her hip.

Silence. One beat. Then two.

Then looks at her watch.

She pulls on the neckline of her dress, looks left and right at her chest.

KELLY
Well, maybe that was an unrealistic expectation.

Kieran hands her the microphone.

KELLY
(to audience)
I know typically in the (air quotes) "standard trans story", there's this whole big glow-up sequence and on the other side, there's this beautiful, happy woman. But that's fiction.
(beat)
Being on oestrogen wasn't a magic pill. It was more like a nicotine patch for sugar, spice, and everything nice. The changes weren't obviously physical. I mean, I didn't even notice myself, at first...
(beat)
But... everyone around me could tell something was different. It was kind of like winning the lottery. I didn't tell anyone, but there were signs.

<u>A2 S4: OFFICE</u>

The office set comes back. Kelly heads offstage. Ellie and Samantha are at the desk. Kelly's laptop is already on her desk, but there's a flower next

to it. Embedded in the flower pot next to the flower, a trans pride flag.

Kelly comes in from off stage, all smiles and joy, wheeling in on a rolling office chair like a hyper-active child.

She's put the camo blue shirt back on.

Arriving at the desk, she rolls her shoulders, typing, while "grooving on good vibes."

SAMANTHA
Kevin! You're in a good mood today! And I see you got a plant.

Samantha doesn't recognize the flag.

SAMANTHA
And a... flag.

ELLIE
Oh, that's so cool! A trans pride flag! For your brother in Norway, right?

KELLY
Uh, yeah. Look, I've been meaning to tell you... I had... a bit of a revelation.

SAMANTHA
What kind of revelation?

Kelly turns to the screens, pointing, genuinely excited.

KELLY
Instead of recalculating state every action, we can just memoize the redux store by hashing previous state. See?

SAMANTHA
Clever. And easier to test, too.

ELLIE
Oh, that'll save us so much in render time.

Nigel comes over, drinking coffee from a mug.

NIGEL
Howdy ladies. And Kevin.

He notices the flag.

NIGEL
That's a cool flag! What is that, Belize?

SAMANTHA
It's a trans pride flag. To show support for his brother.

ELLIE
Seriously, Kevin, you're such a good guy.

Kelly smiles.

KELLY
Aw, I wouldn't say that...

Ellie and Samantha head over to Nigel.

ELLIE
Have you noticed something something different about Kevin?

SAMANTHA
I've noticed that his depression has lifted.

NIGEL
He's got a lot more energy.

ELLIE
Somehow he's got softer skin.

SAMANTHA
He smells slightly better, weirdly.

NIGEL
Is it just me, or is his bald spot making a little bit of a comeback?

Kelly looks over to the group, discussing him, then takes out a mobile phone.

A "Sherlock Text"-like image appears on the back-projected screen: "Worst Case Scenario <Face With Tears Of Joy Emoji > "

A moment later, a reply from Martin: "<Face With Bags Under Eyes Emoji > So, this is real huh?"

Kelly: "I think it is."

Martin: "My condolences. Greta and I are flying over. You're gonna need support for this."

Kelly: "Only if you promise to see my stand-up act."

A2 S5: KING OF STARS PATIO

It is the outside patio of the King of Stars pub. Seated is FAKE KIERAN, someone who vaguely resembles Kieran, but is wearing the same clothing, with a clipboard and a beer.

Kelly is about to go to Fake Kieran. Real Kieran physically holds her back, gently.

Kieran glares at Kelly with Scottish disapproval.

KIERAN
(cold)
Kelly.

KELLY
Yes?

KIERAN
I know this is your story. And you've told me, you need to tell it your own way.

KELLY
Yes...?

KIERAN
Is that supposed to be *me?*

KELLY
Uh... yeah. Why?

KIERAN
Kelly, I am here to support you. But I have to draw the line here.
(beat, intense)
I play me.

Kelly doesn't respond. She just withers under the concentrated cold Scottish glare.

Kieran than goes over to Fake Kieran, and gently shoos them

off the stage, taking their place.

Fake Kieran surrenders the clipboard and beer without protest with the defeated expression of an understudy who has just discovered the principal actor wasn't actually sick.

He picks up the clipboard and the beer.

KIERAN
Right. Now. Where were you?

KELLY
I was about to talk about when we first met.

KIERAN
Ah, yeah. Don't mind me then, go right ahead.

Kelly tentatively approaches Kieran at centre stage. Kieran is looking at his clipboard when Kelly approaches.

KELLY
So, are you Kieran? I heard you run this comedy club... the LGBT comedy club?

KIERAN
It's pronounced "El Gibbity."

Kieran looks up and smiles.

KELLY
Oh. (beat) That's funny.

KIERAN
You don't have to be queer though. It's just that it started as a queer comedy club back in the 1980s. When we really needed a laugh. Aids. Thatcher. Shoulder pads. It's open mic-night this weekend, did you want to sign up for a slot?

KELLY
I did... but, uh... there's something I... need to tell you, first.

KIERAN
Go on?

KELLY
Well, um... I've been... the thing is...

KIERAN
Let me stop you for a moment. I'm an old, gay man who works in theatre. Trust me that whatever you're about to say, you'll get no judgement from me. Unless you voted Tory.

KELLY
(offended)
Well, I'm certainly not a Tory! I can't even vote.

KIERAN
Good man.

KELLY
If I did, I guess I'd vote for the Lib Dems...

KIERAN
I retract the 'good man'. You are now 'adequate man.'

KELLY
I'm really not.

KIERAN
I'm just kidding, you know.

KELLY
I'm not. I'm not a good man... at all. I just... uh, realized... I'm a trans woman.

Kelly winces. Kieran's immediately sympathetic though.

KIERAN
Oh, sit down, love, sit down.

Kelly sits.

KIERAN
I've been dealing with this since the 80s. You've got absolutely nothing to worry about here. And yes, I can give you a slot this weekend. He takes up the clipboard.

KELLY
Thank you. You don't know what this means to me.

Kelly takes off the camo blue shirt, hangs it on the back of her chair.

KELLY
I mean, it's been really overwhelming, right? And I wasn't sure at first. But I think I am sure? And I wanted to do stand-up since I was a kid? But I mean, I wasn't very good. But maybe...

KIERAN
Ma'am.

Getting correctly gendered stops Kelly's spiral.

KIERAN
You're absolutely fine. Now...

Kieran picks up the clipboard with intention.

KIERAN
What name would you like me to put on the poster?

A2 S6: KING OF STARS / FIRST STAND UP AS KELLY

Martin and Greta make their way through the audience, loudly, noisily.

MARTIN
Pardon me. Scuse me. Pardon me...

The backdrop is the King of Stars stand-up act.

The Host from earlier, Fake Kieran, and Kieran all head towards the centre of the stage, all armed with microphones.

They all look at each other, and like the Spider-Man meme, point to each other.

Finally, Kieran gets frustrated.

KIERAN
Kelly!

Kelly heads onstage.

KIERAN
Sort this, would you?

Kieran hands her the "narration" microphone.

MARTIN
I gotta agree with Kieran here, this is getting uncomfortably meta. I mean, Greta and I are in the *audience here*. What are we doing in the audience?

Kelly holds up both hands.

KELLY
(to audience)
Okay. I'll try to explain. So - this was around April 2022, about six months ago.

The background flashes "APRIL 2022, SIX MONTHS AGO."

KELLY
(to audience)
This was the first time I performed stand-up as myself. And Martin and Greta flew in from Norway to see me and support me. I wanted to include this because of two things.

Kelly leans over to speak to Martin in the audience. Greta gets out a mobile phone and points it at the stage.

KELLY
(to Audience & Martin)
First, you flew in from Norway to support me. That's a huge deal and I wanted to let people know about that.

Kelly then turns to Kieran.

KELLY
(to Audience & Kieran)
But the other thing was... what you said when you introduced me. I don't think I'm ever going to forget that. And not just because Greta recorded it on video.

Kieran blushes in pride.

KIERAN
Ah, Kelly...

KELLY
Right. Everybody. Kieran plays Kieran. Ready?

The host and Fake Kieran exit. We're back in the memory.

Kieran jumps to centre stage, and introduces Kelly.

KIERAN
Our next act, though, is a special occasion because our next act is performing for the first time... *as Kelly*.
(beat)
So here's what I want you guys to do. I want you to be part of Kelly’s new family.

Martin claps too early. Realizes. Keeps clapping anyway. The actors all applaud. (The audience might also applaud.)

KIERAN
Ladies, gentlemen--everyone. Kelly O'Connell!

Kelly steps onstage. Kieran offers a fist bump as she passes.

KIERAN
(low, to Kelly)
These are your people.
(beat)
I actually said that?

KELLY
You did. And I'll never forget it.

Kelly and Kieran hug. As they do, the screen changes to the King of Stars patio.

A2 S7: KING OF STARS PATIO / AFTER SHOW

After the show, Kelly, Martin, Greta, Kieran, and a few other comedians sit outside on the patio sharing pints, laughing, telling stories.

Greta takes a candid picture of her face in pure joy.

MARTIN
I like Kelly.

KELLY
I like you too, Martin.

MARTIN
I meant the name, you big dummy! Irish flavour. Good mouthfeel.

KELLY
No new monogrammed luggage.

MARTIN
It suits you.

KIERAN
Actually, your set. It was kind of fabulous.

MARTIN
Yeah, it was *way* better. Your old set used to be... what's the words the kids use?

KELLY
Cringe?

MARTIN
That's the one.

KIERAN
That is interesting. Because it felt like you did stand-up before, but you're saying this is an improvement?

KELLY
Well... practice makes perfect.

MARTIN
No. This was something different. A quantum leap. You looked way more comfortable. Your timing was better. Your material didn't make me worry you needed to be institutionalized.

KELLY
Oh. Yeah. That. I think you might be onto something. I mean, before, it was like... like I was a man performing comedy. Now, it's just... the mic and me.

MARTIN
That tracks.

Martin gets worried. He thinks of something. The other guests move to the wings of the stage, giving Martin and Kelly room.

KELLY
What is it?

MARTIN
I just realized. You're probably going to tell Mom and Dad next, aren't you?
(beat)
ou don't have to.

A pause.

KELLY
Yeah. I'm going to do it when I go home for Thanksgiving. I think I need to do this in person, if I'm going to.
(long beat)
I mean... what kind of a son--

MARTIN
Daughter.

KELLY
--daughter, good catch. What kind of a daughter am I if I can tell strangers from a stage but not the people who love me the most?
(beat)
I want them to see me. But also to see that I'm still me. Just... happier? They always said they wanted me to be happy. And I always felt guilty that I couldn't be happy for them.
(beat)
If I don't do it now, I'll lose my nerve. And they're getting older. Not to be morbid, but... how much time do we really have?
(beat)
Besides it'll be nice to see Aunt Megan, Uncle Shane... Laika.

MARTIN
I get it. I worry about you, but I get it.

KELLY
Will you be there with me?

Martin glances toward Greta.
Greta shakes her head no.

MARTIN
I would. But we burned our leave coming to London. We're saving what's left for Christmas in the States.

GRETA
He promised me Disneyworld!

KELLY
Dawww...

MARTIN
But have me on video. I *really* want to see their faces.

Kelly stares at him.

MARTIN
--and for support.

KELLY
I'll take any support I can get.
(beat)
Actually, if Mom still has them... can I try your old bras?

Martin recoils.

MARTIN
We agreed never to speak of those again.

Everyone exits the stage.

A2 S8: CURBSIDE PICKUP

The background shows a plane taking off in darkness from Heathrow.

Then it descends in daylight.

The backdrop changes to curbside pickup at an American airport -- a sign for "RALEIGH INTERNATIONAL AIRPORT" is on screen.

Kelly arrives, dragging luggage.

Over the pink dress, she's wearing *purple* camo, now.

On screen flashes: "NOVEMBER, 2022." "THREE WEEKS AGO."

Four chairs and a steering wheel, a single, detached front bumper, and a stand-alone cupholder represent Rory's pickup truck.

The truck should be facing the audience. Nothing should obstruct the view of the cupholder.

On the front bumper, a peeling "Support our Troops" ribbon, a "POW/MIA" sticker, and a North Carolina licence plate.

Colleen steps out from the passenger seat, and Rory from the driver's seat. Both are wearing grey wigs - indicating that they've gotten older.

Colleen is wearing Groucho Marx glasses. Kelly stops when she sees them, and laughs.

Colleen and Kelly hug. Then Rory and Kelly - Rory tries to lift her, but then remembers themselves.

RORY
Too old to do that. Keep forgetting.

Rory's wearing a jacket, but there's a bulge under it, the outline of a shoulder holster.

COLLEEN
Welcome home!

RORY
We missed you. Laika missed you too.

KELLY
I missed her so much! Where is she?

A pause.

Kelly turns to Kieran.

KELLY
No. Seriously. Where is she?

Kieran heads offstage.

Kieran returns with Fake Kieran. He hands Fake Kieran a pair of dog ears.

Fake Kieran looks at the ears. Looks at Kieran. Looks at Kelly.

He puts them on, begrudgingly.

Kieran hands him a belt with a tail.

Fake Kieran stares at Kieran.

A beat.

He puts it on.

Fake Kieran is now LAIKA, a Siberian Husky.

KELLY
(exuberant)
Laika!

Laika, (immediately committing to the role) runs straight at Kelly, whining with joy, licking Kelly's face.

Kelly laughs.

RORY
Oh, she missed you! Yes she did!

They all sit down in the truck, Rory driving, Kelly in the passenger seat, Laika behind Rory, Colleen behind Kelly.

Rory starts the truck

SFX: Engine sounds.

The backdrop is North Carolina highways. In it:

* A subdivision entrance: LETS GO BRANDON banner zip-tied to brick.

* An enormous American flag... below an even larger TRUMP flag.

* A lifted pickup with a Thin Blue Line decal.

* A green highway sign: COLONIAL CROSSING, NC.

Laika wedges her snout between the seats, sniffing the cupholder kibble. Kelly and Rory pet her.

Rory unzips his jacket. Underneath, a t-shirt that reads: "MY HUSKY IS SMARTER THAN YOUR HONOR STUDENT"

Also, we see a BLACK PISTOL in a shoulder holster.

Rory adjusts the gun like it's a belt, then uses the same hand to give Laika a treat from the cupholder.

Kelly looks at the gun and is mildly shocked.

KELLY
Dad... you brought a gun to an *airport?*

RORY
Well, yeah, I didn't go inside or anything. I keep it safe.
(shrug)
Same as anyone. Two-A is important. It keeps America free.

KELLY
You do know I live in *London* now. On *purpose*.

COLLEEN
I actually worry about you there. I mean, you're Irish.

KELLY
I'm *American*-Irish. Completely different.

COLLEEN
Says who?

KELLY
The *Irish*. Besides, I've assimilated into British culture. I have opinions on tea now. I've learned to blend. Ba-dum-tish!

Colleen, Rory, and Laika groan.

RORY
Collie-dear, doesn't your brother have connections with the IRA?

Kelly looks at Rory. He's serious. She then turns to Colleen. She isn't laughing.

KELLY
Shane? He's never even *been* to Ireland. You sure this isn't like his Sasquatch story?

COLLEEN
He worked for the Port Authority of Boston in the 90s. He knew people. Boston, you know?

She shrugs.

COLLEEN
That's all I'm saying.

KELLY
Wow. I mean, you think you know someone--

Kelly realises what she just said and winces.

Rory parks the truck, the backdrop is a suburban North Carolina house.

Kieran once again hands Kelly the microphone, as the family heads inside.

KELLY
(to audience)
You'd think this part would have been easy. I mean, my brother broke the O'Connell family trans ceiling twenty years ago. But I was still terrified.
(beat)
I mean, even if they accepted me as a trans woman, I had no idea how they'd react when I told them I was a lesbian.
(beat)
There was a part of me that worried that my dad would say
(imitating)
"Nobody in this family's getting a coochie installed unless they plan to stuff it with penis like the good Lord intended!"

A2 S9: O'CONNELL LIVING ROOM

Kelly sits on a couch, under but slightly offset from a hanging crucifix, while Colleen sits on one of two matching recliners.

Martin appears from stage left, carrying the laptop frame around him.

Rory is offstage.

KELLY
Ah, good. Martin. Video's coming through well. Glad you're here.

MARTIN
Well, virtually.

COLLEEN
So, Kevin, what's the big news?

KELLY
We should wait for Dad.

RORY
I'm coming, I'm coming. Need to put away my gun.

Rory enters, rests a hand on Colleen's shoulder. She smiles up at him.

RORY
So, you've got news?

Kelly squirms.

KELLY
Yeah, actually, and it's kinda big...

Kelly starts to take off the purple camo shirt. But before she can...

COLLEEN
Oh God, it's cancer!

KELLY
What? No!

RORY
You got your girlfriend pregnant?

COLLEEN
You have a *girlfriend*?

KELLY
No. Nobody's pregnant. No one has cancer. Nobody has a girlfriend.

MARTIN
I have a girlfriend.

KELLY
You have a *wife*.

MARTIN
She's *also* my girlfriend.

Greta runs behind Martin's screen and gets in the frame.

GRETA
Hello!

Greta leaves as abruptly as she entered.

COLLEEN
But seriously, you should keep an eye on that. Cancer runs in our family.

RORY
And always use a condom.

COLLEEN
No kids until you're married!
(pointing to crucifix)
You may not believe in God... but you're still *Catholic*.

Kelly looks at where Colleen points. She squints. Then: reaches behind the crucifix -- pulls out a Monopoly bill.

He shows it to Martin, who stifles a laugh.

KELLY
I'm forty-three, Mom.

MARTIN
Teen pregnancy drops off sharply after twenty.

KELLY
Martin, you're not helping.

COLLEEN
For heaven's sake, what is it?

KELLY
It's just... Martin might not be the only trans person in the family.

Silence. Colleen's face falls.

COLLEEN
Oh.

Kelly slowly takes off the purple camo.

Rory turns, heads for the kitchen.

KELLY
Dad?

RORY
I'm refilling my coffee. I'm going to need coffee for this.

Laika follows Rory, who wheels in a coffee machine on the side of the stage.

RORY
Laika. Vet said no.

Laika whines

RORY
It's bad for you.

Laika gets on her hands and knees and begs (like a human)

RORY
(heartbroken)
Laika. No. No coffee for puppies.
(beat, softly)
Laika, we've talked about this.

Back at the couch, Colleen finally processes enough to respond.

COLLEEN
It... doesn't make sense.

KELLY
No, that's just it, Mom. It finally *does*. All my life. The depression. The fog. I knew something was missing.

Rory comes back with his coffee.

COLLEEN
And that something was a...

She can't say the word. She grimaces, making a V-shape with her hands.

KELLY
I mean, psychologically.
(beat)
--though...

RORY
Jesus.

Colleen glares. Martin facepalms.

KELLY
Forget that. Point is, when I look at my life through this lens, the math finally adds up.

Colleen reaches for Rory's hand. He takes it, still standing.

COLLEEN
Give me a moment.

They sit in silence. Rory sits beside her.

COLLEEN
Could it be the autism?

KELLY
If anything, I'm enjoying my autism. I'm a software engineer. I get to be autistic professionally.

Rory nods, considering.

RORY
You think it could be something genetic?

KELLY
Absolutely.

Rory leans back.

RORY
Agent Orange. They say it can pass things on.

MARTIN
Dad, please stop diagnosing things as Agent Orange.

KELLY
Wait... could it?

Kelly turns to Martin. Martin shakes his head.

Colleen leans forward.

COLLEEN
How can you be *sure?*

Kelly takes a deep breath, closes her eyes.

KELLY
Okay. Don't get upset.
(beat)
I tried something. An experiment.

She removes an empty oestrogen patch sachet and hands it to Colleen.

KELLY
Estrogen. T-blockers.

Colleen stiffens. Kelly takes her hand.

KELLY
It's the best antidepressant I've ever taken.

Colleen stares at the sachet, stunned. Rory lifts his hands, overwhelmed, and stands.

RORY
Right. I need fresh air.

He steps to the side of the stage. Laika follows.

Rory mimes tossing a tennis ball for Laika. His expression unreadable. He throws. Laika sprints across the yard.

Rory doesn't watch her. He stares into the distance.

Laika returns, drops the ball at his feet. Rory throws it again.

Laika runs. Rory keeps staring. Repetitive motions.

Back in the living room, Colleen closes her eyes, takes a steadying breath.

COLLEEN
There's one thing I don't get.

MARTIN
One?

COLLEEN
Oestrogen gave me terrible mood swings, cramps, and... ugh. I don't understand how it can be an antidepressant.

KELLY
I don't know either. My brain just runs better on oestrogen than testosterone.

Colleen stares, mouth open. She grabs Kelly's hands.

COLLEEN
Honey, sweetie.
(beat)
Everyone's brain runs better on oestrogen than testosterone.

KELLY
Mom, Martin's *right here*.

MARTIN
Yeah, no. Gotta go with Mom on this one. I've gotten a little dumber on testosterone. At least according to Greta.

Kelly squints at Martin through the screen.

COLLEEN
Have you considered that it might be that you're getting older and that maybe you need *more* testosterone and--

KELLY
Mom. No. Really.
(beat)
I wouldn’t say this if I wasn’t sure.
(beat)
Something finally fits the data.

Awkward silence.

Martin decides to cut in to break it.

MARTIN
I will say... Kevin and I have been talking about this for months. This isn't something they're rushing into.

COLLEEN
I suppose, like Martin, you're going to want a new name.

KELLY
Yeah.

COLLEEN
What is it?

Kelly takes Colleen's hands and looks into her eyes with absolute sincerity.

KELLY
Boomquifa.

A beat.

COLLEEN
What?

KELLY
I want you to call me Boomquifa.

COLLEEN
(frozen)
Boomquifa.

KELLY
Boomquifa O'Connell.

Martin is taken aback. Colleen goes pale.

Finally, Kelly breaks.

KELLY
No. I'm kidding, Mom.

COLLEEN
Thank God.

KELLY
Just preparing you. Figured whatever comes after that will come as a relief.

COLLEEN
Honey. Doesn't work that way.
(MORE)

COLLEEN (cont'd)
(beat)
Just tell me.

KELLY
(hesitating)
Kelly.

Colleen winces -- then goes very still.

A healthy silence.

KELLY
You don't like it.

COLLEEN
I mean... it's better than *Boomquifa*.

KELLY
...okay?

MARTIN
It works. Irish. Familiar.

COLLEEN
What's wrong with... *Kevina*?

A silent pause.

KELLY
Everything.

More silence, Kelly is giving Colleen time to process.

COLLEEN
It was different with Martin. It... made *sense* with Martin.

Then Colleen shakes her head, determination.

COLLEEN
Wait... wait a minute. You can't be trans! You're not even *gay*.

KELLY
I mean, I'm not gay.
(beat)
No -- wait -- I am gay. On a technicality. Gay for women.
(beat)
Lesbian with an asterisk.
(beat)
I'm only gay because I slipped in through the back door...

MARTIN
Kelly. Stop.

Rory comes back in with Laika, who immediately heads over and licks Kelly's hand.

COLLEEN
You didn't wear my dresses, didn't put on makeup. Martin kept stealing your underwear, for crying out loud!

MARTIN
You knew about that?

KELLY
I could give a TED Talk on why those "signs" are nonsense.

MARTIN
Please don't. It's getting late in Norway, I'll fall asleep.

KELLY
The only sign that matters? Every step I take, the pain gets quieter.
(beat)
You always said you wanted us happy.
(beat)
This is how I get there.

There's a moment of quiet after that.

KELLY
Dad? You okay?

A pause. Rory looks away, not in Kelly's general direction.

RORY
I mean, hell, you're forty-three, you're a grown man, you can do whatever the hell you want. Not much I can say about it.
(beat)
We want you to be happy.
(beat)
We *do*.
(beat)
Whatever makes you *happy*.

A long pause.

RORY
Yeah.
(beat)
I'll take the dog for a walk.

Laika leaps up and over to Rory at "walk."

Rory disappears into the bedroom. Returns wearing his coat and newsboy cap, the shoulder holster and black pistol once again visible beneath the open jacket.

RORY
Here, Laika! C'mon Laika-girl. Let's go for a walk.

Rory takes a dog lead that was hanging on the wall, Laika happily following. He leaves with her.

Rory looks back at Kelly.

RORY
Kevin, I--

He stops, shakes his head. Doesn't finish the sentence.

Time stretches in silence for a moment.

Rory exits.

KELLY
I think... Dad needs a little bit of time.

COLLEEN
He does.
(long beat)
I do too.

Colleen gets up.

COLLEEN
I have questions.

KELLY
I'm sure you do.

COLLEEN
But right now, I need to lie down.

MARTIN
Okay. I'll be here if you need me.

KELLY
Yeah, we can pick this up later.

Colleen nods, and then heads offstage.

A moment.

KELLY
(to Martin)
I think that went well.

Martin glares through the frame at Kelly.

LIGHTS DOWN

ACT III: THE UGLY DUCKLING

A3 S1: KING OF STARS

LIGHTS UP

Kelly is at the King of Stars, "Present day" (December 2022), and is holding the microphone, continuing her act.

KELLY
(to audience)
So, where were we? I had just come out. My dad and Laika left to take a walk. Mom had retreated to her room. Knowing her, she probably immediately started praying to Jesus.

Kelly makes a telephone hand gesture. She's doing a "customer service call" bit.

KELLY
(to audience)
(as Jesus)
Heaven: you shiv 'em, we forgive 'em. Jesus speaking.
(as Colleen)
Yes, Jesus... this is Colleen O'Connell. I'm calling about an order I placed for a healthy son and a healthy daughter? The labels got switched.
(beat)
Is it possible... you made a mistake?
(as Jesus)
Whoa, whoa. God doesn't make mistakes.
(as Colleen)
Oh. Right.
(as Jesus)
However...
(beat)
He does occasionally enjoy a good practical joke.

A3 S2: O'CONNELL KITCHEN TABLE

Kelly, Colleen, and Rory are at the kitchen table. Martin is now dressed in blue pajamas, but is still there via laptop frame.

Pizza boxes. Pies and plates. Rory and Kelly are hungry. Colleen is not.

RORY
Bet you don't get good pizza like this in London.

KELLY
Not New York style, no. But London's got good pizza. Mostly from Italian immigrants.

Rory frowns.

COLLEEN
Okay. So...
(pause)
Kelly.

KELLY
Yeah?

COLLEEN
I have to ask. Why *now?*

Kelly swallows.

KELLY
Honestly? I didn't have the *words* before. To explain how I felt. Now... people are more comfortable with telling their stories. And they sound a lot like mine.

COLLEEN
What kind of stories?

KELLY
Well, for me, it was a comic I saw online.

Kelly goes back to eating the pizza, but Colleen is *horrified*.

Kelly finally notices Colleen's blank stare.

COLLEEN
Good lord. A *comic book?*

KELLY
More of a comic strip.

Colleen makes the sign of the cross.

COLLEEN
Oh lord.
(beat)
You got your gender... from *Hägar the Horrible*.

MARTIN
No, that was me.
(beat)
Now I'm a bearded man living in Scandinavia.

KELLY
Mom, the comic I read, the author -- Mae Dean. She figured out she was trans a few years ago. She wrote about it. It felt like she had a direct line into my brain.

The tension eases--slightly.

COLLEEN
And you've really made up your mind?

KELLY
About being trans, yes. About what I do next? I don't know yet. I'm taking it slow.

RORY
Slow is good.

He folds a napkin carefully.

RORY
No sense doing something you can't undo.

He takes a bite. Chews. Too long.

Kelly holds up the purple camo. But doesn't put it on.

KELLY
I'll stay low-key. At least for now. Except where I know I'm safe.

COLLEEN
I suppose I'll have to get used to this then.
(beat)
Kelly...
(beat)
you have to understand... this feels like my son just died.
(beat)
I'm going to need time to... mourn.

Kelly looks away.

KELLY
Mom... I've been trying to die for thirty years. Now I'm finally not.
(beat)
Doesn't that count?

Silence.

COLLEEN
I know.
(beat)
I just... don't feel it?

Colleen presses her thumb into the crust.

The awkward moment lingers.

KELLY
This is why it was so important for me to come home this year. Mom. Dad.
(beat)
I'm still me.
(beat)
Still the kid you raised. Let me show you I'm not a stranger.

COLLEEN
(quiet)
I'm glad you're here. I *am*. I love you so much.
(beat)
And you too, Martin.

MARTIN
If it makes you--

Martin freezes suddenly. Kieran holds a fidget spinner in front of the video frame and spins it.

Then Kieran takes it away and Martin resumes.

MARTIN
--relax, I know Kelly's got this.
(beat)
She's braver than I am. Maybe not as clever.

KELLY
Hey!

MARTIN
She's the Sherlock to my Mycroft.

KELLY
Yeah, if Sherlock missed every obvious clue for thirty years.

Colleen studies Kelly's face. Trying.

A3 S3: KELLY'S ROOM

There is a desk, a chair, a bed, and a free-standing doorframe. A graduation photograph on the desk.

There is also a free-standing rail. On that rail: Kelly's old clothes. The blue t-shirt. The blue college sweatshirt. The blue flannel. And an empty hanger.

Kelly takes out the purple camo... starts to hang it on the hanger...

Then she hears Colleen crying.

Colleen is on the side of the stage, being held by Rory.

COLLEEN
I don't understand.

RORY
Shh, it's alright.

COLLEEN
I had that one cigarette when I was pregnant with Martin... but with Kevin? I didn't even have artificial sweetener.

Kelly looks at the purple camo in her hand. Looks to the door. She takes the purple camo off the hanger, places it on the back of the chair, and leaves the hanger on the desk.

She closes the door. The lights on Colleen and Rory get dimmer, and they get quieter.

Kelly lays on the bed, eyes open.

A sigh of frustration.

The lights go down on Colleen and Rory, as Kieran comes in to hand Kelly the microphone.

Kelly sits up on the bed, facing the audience.

KELLY
(to Audience)
Am I going to tell you that transitioning has solved all my problems? No. Of course not.

Kelly stands up.

KELLY
(to Audience)
For one, it's done absolutely *nothing* to help me track down the one-armed killer who framed me for the murder of my wife.

Kelly shrugs.

In the background, the car is being set up, with two chairs.

A3 S4: COLLEEN'S CAR

KELLY
(to Audience)
But the one thing it absolutely *has* done is help my depression. I remember that I used to get so depressed in winter, I barely had the energy or motivation to even put *up* the Christmas Noose.

Kelly sits down in the passenger side of the car. Colleen is driving.

Colleen's shocked, but laughing, a guilty laugh.

COLLEEN
Kelly, no! You shouldn't be making jokes like that.

KELLY
Aw, Mom. You don't have to worry about me. I wouldn't even know how to tie a noose.

COLLEEN
That's good.

KELLY
I'd have to use a clip-on noose.

Colleen snort-laughs.

KELLY
Like the ones they have for little kids that can't tie their own.

COLLEEN
(laughing)
Jesus!

KELLY
I mean, I tried to google it, but it just spit back the number for the Samaritans.
(beat)
And they didn't know either.

Colleen is trying not to laugh
but can't help but laugh.

KELLY
They call themselves a suicide helpline? Some help they were!

COLLEEN
Kevin -- er, Kelly -- no. Stop it!

Kelly smiles at Colleen.

KELLY
Actually, getting serious for a moment, making jokes about my depression was how I survived it.
(beat)
Not to ruin the mood, but a lot of people like me... don't make it to middle age. Not if we haven't figured it out.

Kelly squirms, clearing her
throat.

KELLY
Point is, my dark sense of humour might have been the thing that saved me. If I can't make jokes about my pain... that's when you know I'm in *real* trouble.

COLLEEN
You know, that's interesting...

KELLY
What is?

COLLEEN
Well, you know, first you were diagnosed with depression. Then Martin was diagnosed with depression. And because of that, I thought to myself, maybe I have depression? And I got diagnosed with it, I'm on Zoloft, I'm doing better.

Kelly shrugs.

KELLY
Yeah, that's true, but remember, both Martin and I turned out to be trans also.
(teasing)
What are you saying, Mom? Think you might be trans as well?

Colleen is quiet. Serious.

COLLEEN
Oh... oh no, Kelly. It's too late for me.

Kelly turns to her. Confused.
Worried.

Colleen keeps on driving.

Silence.

A3 S5: OUTLET STORE

Eventually, Colleen's car pulls into a space. Kelly and Colleen step out. As Kelly steps out, she puts on the purple camo.

KELLY
You okay with this?

COLLEEN
I did it with Martin. Fair's fair. Let's get you some clothes.

Colleen straightens her blouse. A nervous tic.

KELLY
(quiet)
It helps... you being here.

Colleen doesn't smile. She grips her purse strap. Her knuckles pale.

They're inside an outlet store.

Stagehands roll a long line of women's clothing on stage, all of it pink.

A mannequin of a hyper-feminine woman in a cute dress is on display.

Kelly looks at it, while Colleen starts looking through the clothing.

A deep, dysphoric sigh.

KELLY
(sotto)
Attention shoppers: real women wear size four and smile. Good luck, linebacker.

Colleen is looking around, visibly nervous.

Finally, she selects a hyper-feminine pink dress. Smooths the fabric.

COLLEEN
Ke--Kelly.

Kelly turns and joins her.

KELLY
Sorry. I was just in my head there for a second. What is it?

COLLEEN
What about this one?

Kelly eyes it.

KELLY
It's a little... *fru-fru*.

COLLEEN
Isn't fru-fru *good*?

KELLY
I'm aiming for daily wear. Not... coronation day.

COLLEEN
No dresses?

KELLY
Dresses are fine. But I think most Disney princesses would be embarrassed to be seen in that.
(beat)
I'm thinking... less Belle in the ballroom, more Merida axe-throwing.

On the more masculine end, a pink flannel "boyfriend shirt" catches Kelly's eye.

KELLY
Oh. *Hello*. This I could live in.

Colleen blinks.

COLLEEN
Kelly...

KELLY
Yes?

COLLEEN
Those are called *boyfriend shirts*. You'd look like a lesbian.

KELLY
I *am* a lesbian. Lots of lesbians wear flannel.

COLLEEN
Butch lesbians wear flannel.
(MORE)

COLLEEN (cont'd)
(lower)
And they get hurt for it.

KELLY
The neanderthals aren't doing taxonomy, Mom.
(beat)
I just like it. Maybe I'm butch.

COLLEEN
I just don't understand the point of being a woman if you're just going to look like... k.d. lang.

Kelly absorbs that. Then:

KELLY
I don't think there's a *point*, Mom. There's who I am, and who I like to look like.
(beat, quieter)
And I want to look like a woman, not--

COLLEEN
-- a man in a dress?

Silence. Kelly swallows the reply.

COLLEEN
I'm sorry.
(beat)
If you're happy, that's what matters.
(beat)
I just don't always know what happy looks like on you anymore.

They look at different clothing on the rack.

Colleen lifts pink sundresses. Kelly gravitates toward neutral casualwear.

They try to show each other options. Neither approves. The physical distance between them grows. Shopping in parallel.

Colleen finally holds up a UGLY PINK AND YELLOW ROMPER.

COLLEEN
This is adorable. You'd look... darling.

Kelly, resigned, sighs and forces a smile.

KELLY
I can try it.

She takes it. Heads toward the fitting rooms. Colleen pales. Eyes flick to other shoppers.

She gently touches Kelly's arm.

COLLEEN
(quiet, urgent)
Let's not. Not today.
(beat)
I don't want anyone to be cruel to you.
(beat)
We can try them at home. Return what doesn't work.
(soft)
Safer that way.

Kelly blinks.

SFX: TEXT ALERT.

Colleen checks her phone.

COLLEEN
Aunt Megan wants to know if we want lunch.

KELLY
I'm starving. What's she suggesting?

A3 S6: INDIAN RESTAURANT

A suburban Indian restaurant.

AUNT MEGAN (late 60s) -- exuberant, unstoppable -- lights up and barrels toward them, wrapping Kelly in a tight hug.

Kelly is still holding onto the UGLY ROMPER in a shopping bag.

MEGAN
How ya' been, toots!

Over Kelly's shoulder, Megan sees Colleen's frozen smile. Megan's eyes soften. A beat. Then the trickster-grin returns.

MEGAN
Oh, thank God. You told her.

KELLY
Yeah.

COLLEEN
Wait-- what?

MEGAN
Colleen, I love ya, but your poker face is worse than a nun's at *Magic Mike*.
(to Kelly)
How's it feel to be back?

KELLY
Wild ride. I'm okay.

MEGAN
Good. I was running out of ways to not blurt it out during after-mass brunch.

COLLEEN
Blurt *what* out?

KELLY
Mom, I, uh... told Aunt Megan first. On the phone.

A long pause.

COLLEEN
You told Aunt Megan *first*?

Kelly winces.

KELLY
I didn’t want to say it wrong and make it worse.
(shrug)
I needed a test run.

MEGAN
Boy, did she ever. Opened with: "Hey, Auntie M, I have good news and bad news. Good news: I found the source of my lifelong depression. Bad news: it's in my scrotum."

Colleen turns slowly to Kelly.
Kelly withers. A beat.

COLLEEN
Okay, yeah, you *did* need a test run. Good Lord, Kelly. Do not bring up your scrotum unless I specifically ask.
(beat)
I won't.

Megan, Colleen, and Kelly sit down, Megan across from Kelly.

MEGAN
I want the vindaloo, but at my age spicy food is a *medical event*. The eternal struggle.

Colleen smirks.

MEGAN
So, how's life in the land of the oppressors?

The waiter sets down glasses of water with straws.

KELLY
Complicated. London's great. I love it. But it's getting rough for trans people in England.

COLLEEN
Have you thought about moving back here?

KELLY
I haven't ruled it out. And it'd have to be some place queer friendly that I could afford. Maybe Vegas?

Colleen frowns. Megan lights up.

COLLEEN
Not Vegas. It's nothing but insanity, chaos, and risk.

MEGAN
You'd be mayor by Friday.

COLLEEN
Why not Raleigh? Be close to home.

KELLY
Safety.

Colleen fiddles with her napkin.

KELLY
If I can make London work, I will. I've got friends. I know the culture. And the stand-up scene's the best in the world.

Megan grabs her phone.

MEGAN
Oh--I can show your mother your set now!

Email sent. Colleen's phone pings.

MEGAN
It's her act. It's phenomenal.

KELLY
Oh yeah. Greta recorded it. You should take a look.

Colleen's phone rings.

Colleen takes it out and looks at it.

She exhales.

COLLEEN
It's the food bank.
(into phone)
Colleen O'Connell speaking.
(rolls eyes)
Oh, for the love of-- hold on.

She covers the phone.

COLLEEN
Food bank crisis. They need me. Sorry to cut lunch short.

MEGAN
Thanksgiving. Everything's on fire. I'll run Kelly home. Go be a saint.

COLLEEN
You okay with that, Kelly?

KELLY
Gives us time to catch up. Go. You still need two more miracles before canonization.

COLLEEN
Okay, kiddo. Love you.

KELLY
Love you too, Mom.

Colleen hugs Kelly, then exits.

Right before Colleen exits, she stops, closes her eyes, exhales.

Shoulders drop. Then she walks faster.

Megan and Kelly watch Colleen exit.

MEGAN
Honestly, I think your mother's relieved.

KELLY
...relieved?

MEGAN
She's not exactly adventurous with cuisine. Last time I took her here, she ordered butter chicken--
(air quotes)
"as mild as allowed by law." Did the whole Catholic martyr bit -- fanning herself, offering it up to Jesus.

Kelly processes.

KELLY
Oh.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
Right. That.
(then)
She'd love British food. Strange culture. Bland food, spicy comedians.

MEGAN
So, any luck on the romance front?

Kieran comes in to hand Kelly the microphone.

KELLY
(to audience)
So, you have to understand, this story isn't really about my love life because... I don't have one. Yes, I'm a lesbian. But I'm very much a *clearance-rack* lesbian.
(beat)
Slightly irregular, you could say.
(beat)
But, I'm taking hormones. I'm not opposed to the *idea* of surgery. I guess what I'm saying is if any lesbians here are interested... I am available.
(beat)
For pre-order.

Kelly sits back down, handing the mic back to Kieran.

KELLY
I'm not ready. I can't be anyone's boyfriend.

Megan laughs.

KELLY
Right. Girlfriend. Still getting used to that.
(beat)
I just don't think it's in the cards. Lesbians don't want a woman who looks like a man. Straight women don't want... women.

MEGAN
Sweetheart, there are lesbians at my church who'd crawl across glass for you.

Kelly gives her a look.

MEGAN
They're old.
(mischievous)
But they're *spry*.

Kelly snorts.

MEGAN
I went out this weekend. Guy-- Greg.

KELLY
What's he like?

MEGAN
Nice enough. Rodeo. Steakhouse. Then over dinner he mentions he's in the Klan.

Kelly nearly spits out her drink.

KELLY
Jesus.

Megan looks guilty. Kelly clocks it.

KELLY
Aunt Megan...

MEGAN
Other than the Klan thing... we're compatible. There were sparks.

KELLY
A fork and a wall socket are technically compatible. Sparks too.

Megan deflates.

MEGAN
Kelly, I'm nearly seventy.
(half whisper)
Do you know how low your standards sink before bigotry isn't a dealbreaker?

She fidgets with her ring finger. No ring.

MEGAN
I know he's trash. I just forget sometimes that I'm not.

Kelly absorbs that.

KELLY
Being desired is nice. Pretending to be someone else for approval will make you insane.

Megan eyes Kelly's clothes. The purple camo. The UGLY ROMPER in the bag.

MEGAN
Maybe take your own advice?

Kelly pauses, handles the purple camo shirt.

KELLY
Okay. Yeah. I'm a hypocrite. Just... give me time.

Megan squeezes her hand.

MEGAN
I get it. You're staying safe. That's survival. I don't want to eat dinner alone. That's pathetic.

KELLY
You're not pathetic. Just... don't set the bar so low it's a tripping hazard in Hell. The Devil *will* dare you to limbo.

MEGAN
I just wish I had what your parents had.

KELLY
Neuroses?

MEGAN
Got those. I mean fidelity. Stability.

She stirs her straw.

MEGAN
Near the end my ex was cheating. I pretended not to notice. I think I was less upset about the cheating and more upset about his horrible taste in women.

KELLY
Why stay?

MEGAN
People around me... they didn't really talk about divorce. The nuns warned us it was a sin. They shoulda warned us about marrying a dumbass.

Kelly laughs.

MEGAN
Saw him last month. Hospital waiting room. He says,
(disgusted)
"When I think about you, I still get hard."

KELLY
Oh my god. Ew.

MEGAN
I'm living proof being a lesbian isn't a choice. Because *men*.

KELLY
Glad I defected.
(shrug)
Still think the Three Stooges are funny.

A3 S7: COLONIAL PARK

Kieran hands Kelly the mic.

The screen shifts to Colonial Park, a colonial re-enactment park.

KELLY
(to audience)
I'll admit it. Two patches of oestrogen a week and I still think the Three Stooges are funny.
(beat)
I still hold babies like they're live grenades.
(beat)
And sometimes I enjoy the smooth chocolate taste of a Yorkie bar, which used to say NOT FOR GIRLS like an allergy warning for snips, snails, and puppy dog tails.

Rory and Laika wait for Kelly to join them, as Kelly hands the mic back to Kieran.

Rory's BLACK PISTOL is visible even though he has his jacket on.

RORY
Thanks for coming out to walk Laika with me. I figured this was the best way we could talk. Just the three of us, you know?

KELLY
Three?

RORY
I'm including Laika.

Laika nods.

KELLY
Yeah. I don't know if it's men in general or just you, but it seems to be easier for you to process your emotions and thoughts when you're outdoors.

Rory thinks about that.

RORY
Might be something to that. Thing is, I know you and Mom went shopping and... I figure that I should also... take a turn, you know?
(beat)
How'd it go, by the way?

KELLY
She's trying, but...

RORY
Yeah, I get it. That pink and yellow dress thingy your mom picked? What's it called?

KELLY
A romper.

RORY
Yeah. That. That's just ridiculous. And I'm not saying that you'd look ridiculous. I'm saying that *anyone* would look ridiculous. Bettie Page would look ridiculous in it.

KELLY
Just not my style.
(beat)
There was a flannel shirt there I liked.

RORY
Honestly, you look good in flannel. Keeps you warm in London.
(beat)
Honestly, nothing wrong with what you're wearing now.

KELLY
True, but ... when people see me dressed in male... or even neutral... clothes, I look like a man.

RORY
What's wrong with that?

KELLY
I'm not a man.

Rory shakes his head.

RORY
I don't really get it. Martin can dress like a guy, take testosterone... but he's still my girl.

Kelly exhales through her nose.

RORY
Why not just be a man?

KELLY
Why not just be a woman, Dad? Could you?

RORY
Why would I want to? I'm a man.

KELLY
Exactly. It feels right to you. If you tried to live as a woman, it wouldn't work--not because it's hard. Because it's wrong for you.

RORY
Yeah. Because I'm a man.

KELLY
Right.
(steady)
You and Martin both live as men. The difference is: he's trans. You're cis.

RORY
"Cis." What's that?

Kelly stops walking. Stops. Stares. So does Rory.

KELLY
Cisgender.

RORY
Right, but what does it mean?

She stares again. Rory starts walking again.

KELLY
Dad... Martin came out twenty years ago and you never learned what "cisgender" means?

RORY
Never needed it.

Kelly collects herself. Rory adjusts his shoulder holster. Kelly notices.

Laika bumps his hand, expecting a treat.

With the same hand he adjusted his holster with, he pulls a dog treat out of his pocket and gives her one.

KELLY
Do you really take that thing everywhere?

RORY
Yep. You never know.

KELLY
Right. The North Carolina Ninja epidemic.

RORY
Crime's up on the news. Old folks getting robbed.

KELLY
What news? Fox?

RORY
What difference does that make?

KELLY
It makes a difference.

Rory shrugs.

RORY
Well, if old men have guns, they won't get targeted.

KELLY
But you just said they do.

Rory blinks.

RORY
...Anyway, if people didn't have guns, the government could just take over.

KELLY
So we need guns to stop the government from overthrowing... the government?

RORY
(sincere)
Exactly.

VANCE (60s) approaches with his dog, played by the same actor as the Host. The dogs explode with joy. They shake hands.

They exchange business cards.

VANCE
Morning, Rory! Hey Laika!

Rory brightens.

RORY
Hey Vance! Hey Fido!
(to Vance)
This is my son, Kevin.

Kelly freezes. Then smiles politely.

KELLY
Nice to meet you.

Kelly's smile holds half a beat too long.

RORY
He's here for Thanksgiving. Lives in London.

VANCE
London! How *exotic*!
(MORE)

VANCE (cont'd)
(beat)
Oh -- Susan at the kennel said Laika left his toy. Grab it next time?

Rory bristles.

RORY
Her toy. Laika's a *girl*.

Kelly stares, wide-eyed, at Rory.

Laika pets Kelly's shoulder, sympathetically.

Kelly scratches behind Laika's ear.

Kelly, Rory, and Laika pass a sign marking COLONIAL PARK, the historical re-enactment site. Off-season quiet. Locals and the occasional tourist drift through.

They approach a booth where MARTHA (60s) sells "Colonial" baked goods. A handwritten sign says: "AUTHENTIC COLONIAL COFFEE -- $4 (Oat milk extra)." There's a DeLonghi machine.

Laika spots Martha first and lights up.

MARTHA
Hello, Laika! And hello Rory!

She produces a dog treat. Laika accepts, licking her hand. Then sniffs at the coffee machine.

RORY
Hey Martha. How are things?
(to Laika)
Laika... no coffee. Vet said not even decaf.

Martha smiles and squirts out a little bit of whipped cream in a little dish, and gives it to Laika.

MARTHA
Good. And who's this?

KELLY
I'm--

RORY
Martha, this is my eldest son. Kevin.

KELLY
(summoning calm)
I go by Kelly now.

Rory gives her a look. She meets it.

KELLY
Old family name. Very noble. There was a castle. We lost it in a regrettable incident with the English.
(beat)
I'm visiting from London. Too many Kevins there.

MARTHA
London! Must be exciting! Like in that movie with the wizards?

KELLY
(annoyed deadpan)
...You're thinking of New Zealand.

MARTHA
And there's too many Kevins?

KELLY
When I started work, there were already two Kevins: Kevin and New Kevin. So I became New New Kevin. Then they hired another Kevin.
(beat)
I switched to Kelly when they started referring to me as Old New New Kevin.

Rory studies the colonial muffins. Kelly scratches Laika behind the ear.

KELLY
(whispered)
Good girl.

MARTHA
Makes sense. Wouldn't have guessed there were that many Kevins in London, though.

KELLY
Oh yeah. Every Tom, Dick, and Harry's named Kevin.
(beat)
Brexit was mostly about reducing Kevins.

Martha tilts her head.

RORY
Uh, yeah, Martha... we should get going.

MARTHA
Alright. See you soon!

Martha exits.

RORY
I'll say this for England -- Rishi Sunak seems to know what he's doing. I'm jealous of any country that doesn't have Biden in it.
(disgust)
Him and his son. That laptop-- they found all kinds of stuff on it.

Kelly keeps walking, winces.

RORY
Emails, money, hookers... it's all there. They just don't want you to see it.

Kelly exhales.

KELLY
That laptop? It's tainted. No chain of custody. After years of investigations, nobody's shown Joe Biden changed a single policy for his son.

Rory stares straight ahead. He hasn't heard a word.

RORY
How can you be so sure?

KELLY
Dad, I worked in a computer repair shop. I'm a software engineer. I have an M.A. in Journalism. I know what I'm talking about here.
(beat)
The laptop story's got more holes in it than Uncle Shane's Sasquatch encounter.

RORY
Bah. That school filled your head with professor crap. Marxism. Gender stuff. Whatever.

KELLY
Dad. Central Texas University isn't exactly Berkeley. At graduation, they gave me a cowboy hat instead of a mortarboard. Three more credits and I'd have qualified for a minor in Rodeo Science.

They walk in silence.

RORY
You're not voting for Biden next time, right?

Kelly instantly gets a headache.

KELLY
I wouldn't vote for *Hunter* Biden. But he's not running. Joe Biden is.

RORY
Joe stands with Hunter. If Joe's innocent, why not cut him off?

Kelly stops walking.

Rory takes a few steps before turning back.

KELLY
Dad.
(beat)
Dad.
(heavy beat)
Can *you*, of all people, not understand a man *loving a son who disappoints him?*

Rory says nothing. He resumes walking.

Laika looks between them, unsettled.

A3S8: O'CONNELL LIVING ROOM

Back in the living room, Colleen is doing a crossword on her recliner.

Rory heads offstage and comes back, when he does, he no longer has the jacket or gun hostler.

Colleen is stumped. She's got out the Wite-Out / Tip-X, while Kelly hangs up her purple camo.

KELLY
Hey, Mom.

COLLEEN
Kev-Kelly! Oh, thank goodness you're here.

KELLY
What is it?

COLLEEN
I'm stuck on this puzzle. Would you mind taking a look at it?

Colleen hands the puzzle over to Kelly who takes a look at it. Kelly studies it a while.

KELLY
Aunt Megan was helping you with this one, wasn't she?

COLLEEN
She was. How can you tell?

KELLY
17 down's wrong. That's why you're having trouble. "Often raised at inappropriate moments" Five letters. Fourth letter is "I". Should be "Topic."
(beat)
Not "Penis."

Colleen blushes.

Colleen puts the crossword away.

COLLEEN
Anyway--what was that show you mentioned? The British one you thought I'd like?

KELLY
Oh yeah, do you have time now?

Rory sits down at a table, sitting down with a laptop.

KELLY
Dad? You want to join us?

Rory smiles.

RORY
Not really my thing, comedy. But I know it's yours and Mom's. And I really like seeing you two enjoy it.

Kelly smiles back.

Colleen and Kelly then start watching television.

Kieran hands Kelly the microphone.

In the background, on the screen, we can see Rory's laptop screen. On it: A search engine.

He types in "Transgender Science Study."

KELLY
(to audience)
That's the thing about my family. They try. They really do. And sometimes, when they try, they surprise you.

In the background, on Rory's laptop, the top result is:

NHS ENGLAND-INDEPENDENT REVIEW OF GENDER IDENTITY SERVICES FOR CHILDREN AND YOUNG PEOPLE: INTERIM REPORT

He clicks it. Chooses "PRINT"

SFX: Inkjet printer.

LIGHTS DOWN

ACT IV: THE TURKEY

A4 S1: RALEIGH CURBSIDE PICKUP

LIGHTS UP

Raleigh International Airport.

The screen flashes: "THANKSGIVING DAY. NOVEMBER 2022"

Megan is helping Uncle SHANE (80) into her car. The smile never leaves Shane's face -- like he's forgiven the world in advance.

As he gets in, Shane pats Megan's hand with quiet gratitude, like she did him a favour he can't repay.

They smile. Relaxed. Then suddenly:

SHANE
Have you ever seen a sasquatch drunk off his ass on Hennessy?

Megan groans.

MEGAN
Shane, you've told this story before. It gets less realistic every time.

SHANE
Well, I'm just telling you what I saw.

Megan nods. Drives.

Shane stops for a second. Then continues anyway.

SHANE
He was drinking it straight from the bottle. This was behind the--

MEGAN
Cracker Barrel on South Street.

SHANE
Cracker Barrel on South Street.

SHANE
So, I *have* told you this story.

MEGAN
Yes, Shane, you have.

SHANE
It's just that... I'll never forget it. Hairy as all hell. And the smell! Face like an ape. Hands the size of a bread box. And he was hung like--

MEGAN
(interruption)
Yeah, Shane. I know.

SHANE
I mean, that's what they say about men with big feet.

Megan rolls her eyes.

MEGAN
How are things up in Boston?

SHANE
Cold. Wet. Damp.

MEGAN
How are the Sox doing?

A pause. Shane's brow furrows in confusion, and he looks down to his feet.

SHANE
Same. I should change them when we get to your place.

A moment.

SHANE
Oh. You mean the *Red* Sox. Sorry, I'm a little slower on the uptake these days.

MEGAN
Aren't we all?
(not casual)
I'm thinking about retiring.

SHANE
So am I.

MEGAN
Shane... you're already retired.

This comes as a surprise to Shane.

SHANE
I was wondering why work wasn't complaining about my absence.
(MORE)

SHANE (cont'd)
(beat)
So, who else did Colleen invite?

MEGAN
Me, you, Declan and his girlfriend... and Ke--Kevin flew in from London.

SHANE
Martin's not coming?

MEGAN
He's spending Thanksgiving in Norway. Couldn't get the time off.

SHANE
Ah. That stinks. Well... maybe this year's a break from all that queer stuff.

Megan bristles.

MEGAN
What do you mean by that?

SHANE
I hate talking about it. I never remember the lingo.

MEGAN
The *lingo?*

SHANE
I'm afraid I'll say the wrong thing. Hurt Martin by accident. Last time I needed a flowchart. Like "twink." I thought that was the Irish singer.
(beat)
I think my doorman's gay. Might've hit on me. Asked if I was a "power bottom." I told him mine's still hand-cranked.
(beat)
Nice guy, though.

Megan laughs--relieved.

Shane smiles, relieved she's laughing too.

MEGAN
Shane, are you making this up?

SHANE
(bittersweet)
That's the problem. I'm so old now, I can't tell.

A4 S2V: O'CONNELL LIVING ROOM

The O'Connell living room. Colleen is sitting on her

recliner with a laptop on her lap.

Kelly's performance, recorded by Greta plays. We can hear Kieran's introduction:

KIERAN
(recorded, tinny)
Ladies, gentlemen--everyone. Kelly O'Connell!

Colleen smiles. Genuinely maternally proud. Laughs a little.

SFX: Car pulling into driveway.

Colleen *snaps* the laptop shut -- too fast -- sets it aside, and heads to the side of the stage.

There, she opens the door to DECLAN (40s, effortless, unexamined masculinity,) and his girlfriend MAUREEN (30s, poised, unselfconscious femininity).

Immediate warmth.

DECLAN
Auntie Colleen! Eyyyy!

He scoops her into a hug.

COLLEEN
Declan! Maureen!

Colleen hugs her too.

COLLEEN
Come in!

They enter. Declan drops onto the couch, sprawling. Maureen smooths her skirt before sitting.

MAUREEN
(to Colleen)
I love that dress!

COLLEEN
Thank you! It has pockets! How was the drive?

DECLAN
Stressful, as always. Thanksgiving traffic. Nobody knows how to drive.

MAUREEN
Dec, sweetie. Indoor voice.

DECLAN
Oh. Sorry. God, the turkey smells great!

COLLEEN
We're doing two this year. One traditional, one deep-fried. Rory's idea.

Colleen, Declan, and Maureen exit. Rory and Kelly take centre stage.

A4 S3: O'CONNELL BACKYARD

The O'Connell backyard. There, a turkey deep-fryer. The kind you see in YouTube videos because of the spectacular explosions that ensue. Also: a turkey. Dubiously thawed.

Rory is wearing heavy apron and gloves, grinning from ear to ear.

Kelly has an apron and gloves as well, but hasn't put them on yet. She also wears the purple camo.

Kelly looks at the audibly BUBBLING oil, then back to the turkey, then back to the oil.

She walks over to the turkey. Pokes it with her finger.

KELLY
Y'know, Roman seers used to predict catastrophe from studying bird carcasses.
(beat)
Now I know how they felt.

RORY
It should be fine if we follow the instructions.

KELLY
Where are the instructions?

RORY
I gave them to you.

They stare at each other. Kelly shakes her head, no. The oil

bubbles just a little *too* aggressively.

KELLY
That oil looks way too hot.

RORY
It's meant to be hot. It’s fine. I watched a video. It’s basically just... lowering it slowly.

KELLY
Into boiling oil.

RORY
Peanut oil.

KELLY
Oh, well, that’s different. I was worried it was Quaker State.

Kelly pokes the turkey with her finger again.

KELLY
Is that fully thawed?

RORY
It's been out since this morning.

Kelly looks at Rory incredulously.

KELLY
That's not an answer. It's an *omen*.

The back door opens. Declan comes out first, with a beer in hand. Maureen follows, followed by Colleen.

Rory lights up.

RORY
Declan!

DECLAN
Uncle Rory! Kevin! Great to see you!

KELLY
Hey, Declan.

DECLAN
Oh, Kevin, I don't know if you've met yet. This is my girlfriend, Maureen.

Kelly's eyes flick to Maureen's painted nails... soft blouse...

tucking her hair behind her ear. Easy poise.

She offers a handshake instead of a hug. Maureen takes it warmly.

MAUREEN
Nice to meet you. Dec says you're hilarious.

KELLY
Mm.

Kelly unconsciously curls her left hand into a fist.

RORY
Declan, you ready to go shooting Saturday?

DECLAN
Am I ever! So, what's all this?

RORY
Perfect timing, actually. Want to help me deep-fry a turkey?

KELLY
(sotto)
Oh no.
(beat)
He's found backup.

She backs away from Rory, and places the apron and gloves on a patio table.

KELLY
Dad, I'm not doing this.

She gestures to the fryer.

KELLY
I was not planning on facing death this trip.

Colleen gently draws Kelly aside, gently taking her by the arm.

COLLEEN
Say, could you help me grab a few things from the car?

KELLY
Sure, Mom.

Colleen and Kelly head off to the side.

Rory claps Declan on the back, pride glowing in a way Kelly never sees, his laugh dropping half an octave.

RORY
Hah! Come on. Let's get this turkey in the bath.
(beat, to Declan, lower voice, excited)
I can show you my toys while it cooks.

Declan and Rory remain on stage, upstage of Colleen and Kelly. Declan slips on the gloves and apron.

There are pies, and a bag, on a table. Colleen grabs the pies and hands them to Kelly.

In the background, Rory hooks the turkey onto the perforated turkey rack.

KELLY
Thanks for the save back there. I know women sculpt their eyebrows, but I don't want mine burned off.

Colleen frowns, pacing nervously.

COLLEEN
Kelly... I wanted to talk to you. About dinner. Your uncle Shane... he's getting up there. And your dad, too. We're at that age where we won't be around forever.

Kelly freezes.

KELLY
Is this about to get morbid? I'm holding *pie*.

Kelly sets the pie back down on the table.

In the background, Rory and Declan are about to dip the turkey in the oil. They're moving slowly and carefully.

KELLY
Mom. C'mon. What's going on?

Colleen fidgets.

COLLEEN
Would you maybe... not wear a dress? Just be Kevin. Just for Thanksgiving.

Kelly rubs her temples.

The deep fryer bubbles, causing Rory and Declan to take a half-step back... but they resume attempting to immerse the turkey.

KELLY
You never asked Martin to wear a dress.

COLLEEN
I know. It's just... so everyone's comfortable. Who wants drama on Thanksgiving? And Martin... was always--

KELLY
I get it. It's different.
(beat)
I'm not thrilled, but I get it. You want a Thanksgiving that's happy. Not...

COLLEEN
Dramatic.

KELLY
Yeah.

Kelly frowns. Hangs her head. Rory and Declan finally finish lowering the turkey. No disaster... so far.

KELLY
Thanksgiving makes you happy.
(quiet)
So... one dinner as Kevin. One.

Colleen pulls her into a hug. Kelly hugs back.

Kelly's face -- unseen by Colleen -- reveals the cost. Eyes opened. Strained expression. On Colleen's? Relief.

They break.

KELLY
I'll go get changed for dinner.

COLLEEN
Oh, speaking of which, don't forget your bag.

Colleen grabs the pies. Kelly sees the bag. She looks in,

pulls out what's in it. It's the UGLY ROMPER.

She stuffs it back in the bag, harder than necessary, and leaves it behind as she leaves.

A4 S4: O'CONNELL KITCHEN TABLE / LIVING ROOM

While we're clearly in the living room, the rear projection should show the backyard *through* the living room windows, specifically to keep an eye on the boiling turkey fryer.

On the kitchen table, guns of all types. Somewhere between a gun show booth and *Lord of War*.

Specifically, there is Rory's BLACK PISTOL in his shoulder-holster, on the table, as well as a SILVER REVOLVER.

And an AR-15. Rory proudly shows it to Declan.

RORY
This is an AR-15.

DECLAN
Cool. An assault rifle!

RORY
It's not an assault rifle. That's just what the anti-gun lobby calls it.

DECLAN
(accepting)
Oh. Yeah. So what does AR stand for?

RORY
ArmaLite. The company that designed it.

DECLAN
Makes sense.
(beat)
Why not AL-15?

Rory thinks.

RORY
...no idea.

Kelly enters. She's changed into a *full blue suit* over the dress.

She's twitchy and uncomfortable in it.

Then she sees the table, gets wide-eyed, then sighs in resigned acceptance.

Colleen is sitting in her recliner, unfazed, opening a crossword.

COLLEEN
(without looking)
You'll have those cleared off before dinner, right, hun?

RORY
Will do, Collie-dear.

Kelly moves into the kitchen, looking around. She finds what she's looking for -- a tea box.

She opens it. Looks inside.

She pulls out a Monopoly bill. Rolls her eyes. Then a tea bag.

In the backyard, through the (projected) window, the deep fryer bubbles violently. A burst of steam-- oil spits outward with a BANG.

They all look to the window.

Then... it calms.

RORY
That's just moisture burning off.

DECLAN
Yeah. You always get that.

Kelly takes a breath. Looks around for a kettle.

Another smaller POP from outside. This time, nobody except Kelly reacts, and even her reaction is restrained.

DECLAN
So, Uncle Rory, what's your concealed carry?

Rory shows the BLACK PISTOL.

RORY
Glock 19. Compact. Practical. The Toyota Corolla of guns.

DECLAN
Nothing flashy?

RORY
Flashy gets you killed. Practical keeps you alive.

Kelly can't find the kettle.

KELLY
Mom, do you still have the electric kettle?

COLLEEN
Bottom cabinet, right.

Declan looks at a SILVER REVOLVER on the table, points to it.

DECLAN
What about this one?

Declan picks it up, curious. He opens the cylinder and checks that it's unloaded.

Satisfied, he spins the cylinder, then snaps it shut and examines the sights, keeping it pointed safely away from anyone.

RORY
I'd stay away from revolvers.

Declan puts it back.

DECLAN
Why?

RORY
Too simple. Nothing between the thought and the trigger.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- here's a good one. Highest point of achievement, or supplier of faulty hunting gear. Four letters.

KELLY
Acme.

Rory lifts a shotgun.

RORY
Now this one's a favourite. Mossberg 500.

Kelly eventually finds the kettle. She starts making tea.

RORY
I had the Second Amendment engraved on it. Take a look.

He turns the shotgun to show Declan. The barrel sweeps directly across Kelly.

Kelly freezes -- flinches, instinctively leans back, then ducks.

KELLY
Jesus!

Nobody else reacts. A half-beat.

Rory lowers the gun.

RORY
Sorry, Kevin. Did I accidentally muzzle you there?

Declan doesn't react. Colleen doesn't look up.

KELLY
Jesus, Dad. You keep it pointed down for a reason!

RORY
Sorry about that.

KELLY
You're the one always going on about gun safety.

RORY
Oh -- reminds me. You and Declan can help me install a gun safe later.

KELLY
What happened to the old one?

RORY
Nothing. I'm adding a fourth.

KELLY
A fourth? How many guns do you actually have?

RORY
About eighty-ish.

A moment.

KELLY
(shocked)
Eighty... ish.
(a beat)
Eighty-ISH*!?*
(beat)
Dad, I know you keep saying you're a responsible gun owner... but no responsible gun owner owns a number of guns ending in *-ish*.

RORY
I'm a collector.

KELLY
Mom's a collector too. Nobody dies if a *Hummel* accidentally discharges.

Silence.

RORY
You don't like guns. I get it. Why can't I have a little fun with my toys?

KELLY
Dad...
(beat)
It's not that I don't like guns. It's that I'm not safe on bad days.
(beat)
You know that.

Rory's jaw tightens. He says nothing.

Kelly pinches the bridge of her nose.

KELLY
Forget it. We'll talk after Thanksgiving.
(beat)
But the first thing you ever taught me about guns was this: "guns are not toys."

Kelly starts to exit, abandoning the tea.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- unaware of what's right in front of you. Nine letters.

KELLY (O.S.)
Oblivious.

COLLEEN
No. Third letter's an S.

A long beat. Dead air.

KELLY (O.S.)
Insensate?

COLLEEN
Insensate! Thank you, Kevin!

SFX: Doorbell.

Aunt Megan and Shane arrive at the door. Colleen gets up to let them in.

Kieran comes up and hands the mic to Kelly.

KELLY
(to audience)
That's the thing about my--

Kelly doesn't get to finish her sentence. Colleen comes up to her, and *interrupts*.

COLLEEN
Kevin, Aunt Megan and Uncle Shane are here.

Kelly looks at Colleen, then to Kieran.

Kieran shrugs. Kelly hands the mic back to Kieran and heads towards the door, where Megan and Shane greet her with a smile!

SHANE
Kevin! So good to see you! How's life in London?

KELLY
Damp, but good.

MEGAN
So... Kevin?

Kelly winces.

KELLY
Yeah, Auntie M. Kevin. All day.

Megan hugs her, tight. Shane joins, obliviously turning it into a group hug.

SHANE
And the stand-up? Am I going to see you on Letterman?

Kelly smiles.

KELLY
Working on it. Had a breakthrough. Stage presence is better.

Megan nudges her shoulder. Kelly nudges back.

SHANE
There was something important I forgot... ah well. It'll come back.

Shane drifts toward Maureen.

Megan gently guides Kelly away from the rest of the family towards the side of the stage.

SHANE
And you must be Declan's girlfriend.

Maureen offers her hand. Shane kisses it.

SHANE
Enchanté!

DECLAN
(playful)
Stop stealing my girlfriends, Uncle Shane!

SHANE
Me? Never!

Shane spots the guns on the table. Studies them. Concerned.

SHANE
Oh. Rory. Happy Thanksgiving.

Shane's eyes don't leave the guns.

RORY
Happy Thanksgiving, Shane. How are things in Boston?

SHANE
Eh. Pretty good. Uh...

He glances around, lowers his voice.

SHANE
(quiet)
You sending any of this to our boys in Derry?

A tiny beat of silence.

RORY
What?

SHANE
(concerned)
Rory, you're a good bloke, but I think we should give Good Friday a chance.

RORY
...what?

A4 S5: O'CONNELL HOME / MEGAN'S ASIDE

A side-stage conversation between Megan and Kelly.

MEGAN
How are you holding up, Kelly?

Kelly looks at the suit she's wearing.

KELLY
Just Kevin for today. This is Mom's holiday, you know.

MEGAN
Did Colleen ask for that?

KELLY
Weaponized Irish Catholic Mom guilt.

MEGAN
I see. I'll follow your lead. Ke--

She stops, unsure.

KELLY
Kevin is fine.

MEGAN
Alright, Kevin. But I want you to know. You were right. I deserve better.
(beat)
Kelly.
(beat)
So do you.

Kelly exhales. Lets it land.

KELLY
You're right. I know you're right. But Mom's barely keeping it together. If I push, today becomes about me.
(beat)
Shane, Declan... Maureen seems nice. It'd be a lot.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
I'll decide who to tell, and when. Nobody needs a Thanksgiving ambush.

Megan and Kelly step back to center stage, rejoining the family.

But now, standing in the middle of the room like a spectre: FATHER PATRICK (60s). Gaunt. Stern. Silent. A black zip-up hoodie pulled over his head.

Megan registers mild surprise. Kelly freezes.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- this is Father Patrick, from the food bank. I invited him to Thanksgiving. He would've been on his own.

Wordlessly, Father Patrick removes the hoodie.

He reveals a priest's collar.

A4 S6: THANKSGIVING DINNER

Thanksgiving.

Places, facing the audience, from stage left to stage right: Rory, Colleen, Shane, Megan, Kelly, Declan, Maureen, Father Patrick.

Two turkeys. One oven-cooked and roasted to perfection. The other, one side is over-charred. The skin is blistered and split. The shape is slightly warped and collapsed. Not grotesque. But clearly wrong.

A din of plates being passed around, everyone's already tucked in, we join in media res.

RORY
I think the fried turkey came out alright. Bit darker than expected, but that's the oil temp. Locks in the flavour.

DECLAN
(supportive)
Looks savage.

MAUREEN
So, Declan tells me you work at a food bank, Colleen?

COLLEEN
Mm. Yes -- Our Mother Of Mercy.

MAUREEN
What's it like?

COLLEEN
Exhausting, honestly. It seems like every year, there are more people who need help.

DECLAN
Yeah, people are struggling. Not much you can do.

Kelly slow blinks.

KELLY
I wouldn't say that--

MAUREEN
What would you say?

KELLY
When wages don't keep up with--

COLLEEN
Kevin, this is Thanksgiving. Is this the time for politics?

KELLY
I'm not--

RORY
We'll agree to disagree.

Forks clink. Declan chews too loudly.

KELLY
Sorry. I didn't mean--

RORY
Let's not get into it.

Shane smiles, confused.

SHANE
People used to help their neighbours more.

DECLAN
Exactly.

KELLY
Actually--

COLLEEN
There it is again.

MAUREEN
Kevin, sweetheart, no one's arguing with you.

Father Patrick clears his throat. Silence floods the space Kelly occupied.

Kelly nods. Picks up her fork. Doesn't eat.

DECLAN
People just want stability. Not handouts. Just a fair shot.

Kelly's fork hovers. She doesn't bite.

SHANE
You used to raise a family on one income.

COLLEEN
Exactly.

KELLY
People still want that life. They just can't afford it.

RORY
Kevin. That's enough.

COLLEEN
Why are you so angry all the time?

KELLY
I'm not angry.

The table stills.

COLLEEN
We just don't want a fight.

KELLY
I know.

RORY
Okay, okay, everyone breathe.

There's no conversation for a few moments. Just the sound of forks on plates and silent chewing.

Father Patrick stares, directly at Kelly. A slow sip of coffee. Kelly notices, and shrinks in her seat.

COLLEEN
You've always been... sensitive.
(beat)
I mean that kindly.

KELLY
I'm not--

Kelly looks to Megan.

MEGAN
I'd say... empathetic? Not--

MAUREEN
Histrionic?

MEGAN
Right. We could use more sensitivity.
(turning)
Wouldn't you agree, Father Patrick?

Father Patrick slowly nods. No warmth.

SHANE
I'm sensitive too. Switched toothpaste. Can't drink ice cold beer anymore. Kevin, in London ,do they serve beer warm?

KELLY
Not warm. Just not iced to death. They want you to taste it. American beer's more about being light. Clean.
(beat)
Unobtrusive.

MEGAN
More palatable for consumption.

Kelly nods.

MEGAN
Pass the mashed potatoes?

MAUREEN
So, when will you be moving back to the States?

KELLY
Not planning to at the moment.

DECLAN
(incredulous)
So you're going to stay there?

KELLY
I think so. I like it there.

MAUREEN
Wow. I just couldn't imagine living anywhere else but the U.S.

RORY
Must be a lot of crime over there. All the immigrants. No guns.

Kelly inhales. Her hand trembles as she lifts her water glass. She sets it down carefully.

Sound drops slightly. Conversation continues, muffled.

Kelly freezes. Everyone else keeps moving for two or three seconds.

Voices get quieter and quieter.

MEGAN
This is very good.

SHANE
Did I get the good seat this year?

COLLEEN
Anyone need salt or pepper?

FADE SLOWLY
TO SPECIAL
ON KELLY

Kelly just stays there, frozen.

The ensemble strip away the thanksgiving dinner and replace it with dessert.

LIGHTS RISE

Kelly is in precisely the same position.

Pies, Cool Whip, plates. Ceramic scrapes loudly in the quiet.

COLLEEN
Kevin?

Colleen is holding a pie cutter. Kelly startles.

KELLY
Oh -- no, thank you.

COLLEEN
You sure? Suit yourself.

SHANE
I'll have whatever's easiest on the stomach.

COLLEEN
Pumpkin it is.

Father Patrick drinks his coffee black. Silent.

RORY
This turned out nice.

Murmurs of agreement.

Kelly stares at her empty plate. Sighs. Almost over.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- I watched your stand-up set online. I liked it.

KELLY
You did?

COLLEEN
I did. Why don't you pull it up on the big TV? Show everyone.

Kelly freezes.

KELLY
Mom... is that a good idea?

COLLEEN
Why wouldn't it be?

KELLY
My set... isn't exactly for polite company.

COLLEEN
Oh, I didn't mind.

KELLY
It's not just the jokes.

COLLEEN
You mean the dress?

Kelly blinks.

KELLY
Uh--

Colleen pours coffee.

COLLEEN
Oh, don't worry. Everyone in the family knows.

Silence.

KELLY
Everyone... *knows*.

Kelly scans the faces. Megan is stunned. But no one else looks away.

COLLEEN
Well, once you told Megan, I figured family was fine.

KELLY
(soft)
You told them. *Before dinner*.

A half-beat.

Shane snaps his fingers.

SHANE
That's what I forgot to tell you! I knew it was important. Right, Kevin -- congratulations on coming out.
(beat)
So... is this part of the act, or... your life now?

Kelly doesn't answer.

She stares into her coffee.

Kieran comes by with the microphone. Offers it to Kelly.

Kelly looks at the microphone. Then looks at Kieran.

She slowly shakes her head, "no."

KELLY
I'm sorry.
(long beat)
There's just nothing funny about this.

LIGHTS DOWN

ACT V: THE SILLY GOOSE

A5 S1: O'CONNELL LIVING ROOM

LIGHTS UP

It's nighttime.

Rory and Kelly are watching TV in the recliners.

We stay with them a moment.

Kelly enters from offstage. Moving slowly.

She's not wearing her dress. Instead, she's wearing a grey t-shirt and grey sweatpants.

Rory and Colleen don't notice. They don't even look away from the screen.

COLLEEN
Hey. Welcome back.

RORY
If you want decaf coffee, we moved the mugs above the coffee machine.

KELLY
I fell asleep. Where is everyone?

COLLEEN
Declan and Maureen went back to their hotel. Father Patrick drove home. Shane's staying with Megan.

RORY
We figured the turkey knocked you out.

Kelly heads over to the coffee maker.

TUCKER-LIKE ANCHOR (O.S.)
Some doctors now say many children seeking puberty blockers may be responding to social pressure rather than medical need.
(beat)
And yet the treatments continue, even though there's still no long-term evidence they're safe.

Kelly shuts her eyes. Tries to ignore it.

Silence. The coffee machine hums.

COLLEEN
I just don't understand why anyone would do that to a kid.

Kelly tries to contain it -- but she can't.

KELLY
(rage)
Oh for the love of--!

Colleen turns. Rory keeps watching the TV.

COLLEEN
Kelly?

KELLY
He's lying. He *knows* he's lying.

A pause.

COLLEEN
I still don’t think a child can make that decision.

KELLY
Kids can't get blockers without parental consent. And the point is to delay the decision until they're old enough to decide for themselves, instead of making an irreversible decision for them.
(beat)
God, I wish I'd had that chance. If I'd known... I would have asked. Even back then.

Rory leans forward towards the TV, ignoring Kelly.

COLLEEN
Kelly, you're in your forties, why do you care about puberty blockers? It's a little late, isn't it?

Kelly's composure cracks.

KELLY
Mom, that's the *point*.
(near tears)
I've had moments before. When I thought I might be trans. But every time, I pushed them down because I thought -- my brow, my bones, my voice -- that I'd just be an ugly woman.
(beat)
And after forty years of my body producing testosterone... maybe I am. Just... an ugly woman.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
I missed my chance to be pretty.
(beat)
I hate that that matters. But it does.
(beat)
I don't *ever* want another kid to feel like I did.
(quiet)
To go through puberty... as a mutilation.

Colleen scoffs.

COLLEEN
Oh, come off it, Kelly. You weren't *mutilated*.

Kelly breaks.

KELLY
(shouting)
What the...!? Where do you get off telling me that?

KELLY
(shouting)
Do you think I'm doing this for kicks? I've always felt wrong, ugly -- This isn't politics. These are kids trapped in bodies they can't escape!

COLLEEN
(shouting)
Where do I get off? You're the one dressing like a clown, insisting something's wrong when there isn't -- and you're yelling at me? On Thanksgiving?

KELLY
You need to care about people who aren't you!

COLLEEN
Go to your room.

Silence.

KELLY
What?

COLLEEN
That's enough, Kevin! Go. To. Your. Room. How dare you yell at me in my own house!

Kelly closes her eyes. Jaw tight. She turns. Walks away.

Rory watches. Says nothing.

COLLEEN
(calling after)
And yes, I'm calling you Kevin! That's the name you had as a child -- and you're acting like one!

A5 S2: KELLY'S ROOM - NIGHT

Kelly is *done*. Slams the door. Opens her suitcase. Her pink dress goes in first -- rushed, crushed.

A gentle knock at the door.

Kelly looks upward. Grunts. She turns.

Rory opens the door without waiting. Reading glasses. A printed report in his hand, marked up.

RORY
Hey, uh-- listen. I was reading something.

He holds up the report.

RORY
This is from the NHS. It says kids shouldn’t be on blockers.

Kelly inhales slowly.

KELLY
Is that *the Cass Review*?

Rory checks.

RORY
Uh... yeah. Cass.

KELLY
It's not science. It's politics wearing a lab coat.

RORY
You don't *know* that.

KELLY
That report hurt people I know. Real kids, Dad. Not headlines.

RORY
You don't know what those drugs will do to those kids.

KELLY
I know what *not* having them did to me!

Rory tightens. Kelly continues.

KELLY
God, as if it wasn't bad enough for trans kids, along comes the NHS telling kids: your feelings aren't real, there's something wrong with your brain.

RORY
Kevin, you can't be reasoned with, sometimes.

KELLY
Dad, I have been *beyond* reasonable here.

RORY
But what if it really *is* mental illness? What if it's something that can be fixed? I'm not saying it is. I'm saying... I'm just saying. Have you even *tried therapy* for the trans stuff? Because you're starting to sound like a paranoid delusional.

Kelly stops and stares at him. Deep breath. Forced calm.

KELLY
Don't, Dad. Don't go there. I am *sick and tired* of you treating me like an unreliable narrator of my own life. At what point will you just *accept* that I know my own *mind?*

RORY
And what if you're wrong?!

Kelly looks at Rory. Her face falls. Sadness. Disappointment.

KELLY
Dad, I just need some time right now.

Rory's still determined, but he knows to walk away before things get more heated.

RORY
Alright. We'll be downstairs.

Rory leaves. Kelly stands there. Then sits on the bed.

KELLY
(to self)
Every time.
(beat)
If I knew something--I was wrong. If I felt something--
(stops herself)
"Too much." "Overreacting."
(beat)
Jesus.
(quiet)
Why would I *ever* trust myself?

She picks up an oestrogen patch from her luggage.

KELLY
(soft, realizing)
But I did the math.
(beat, conviction)
I'm *right*.

A5 S3: MARTIN'S FLAT/KELLY'S ROOM

Kelly picks up her phone.

The rear projection splits, as lights reveal Martin, asleep with Greta. Martin is wearing blue pajamas.

Kelly dials Martin.

SFX: Phone ring.

Martin grabs his phone off the bedside table, looks at it, groans.

SFX: Beep.

He puts the phone down on bedside table then collapses back to sleep.

Kelly looks at the phone on her end.

KELLY
He hung up.

Kelly dials again.

SFX: Phone ring.

Martin's eyes snap open this time. He sits up, brow furrowed. He picks up the phone.

MARTIN
Kelly. It's half past one.

KELLY
I... really need to talk to you.

LIGHTS FADE DOWN

Martin moves from his bedroom to sit in a chair in the living room.

LIGHTS FADE UP

Martin rubs his face, bleary eyed. Drinks coffee.

MARTIN
Wow.

KELLY
I know, right?

MARTIN
I was hoping it wouldn’t go like that.
(beat)
I should’ve warned you better.

Kelly sits on her bed. Her breathing is slightly off, she's still upset.

KELLY
How could you have known? They were fine with you being trans. I don't know why it's different.

MARTIN
Kelly... they accepted me because I went from daughter to son.

The realization hits her. She covers her mouth with her hand in shock.

MARTIN
Did you think they'd be fine with you becoming a daughter?

Kelly exhales. Shakes her head.

KELLY
Ah Shishkabob.

MARTIN
Yeah.
(beat)
For them... that’s not the same thing.
(beat)
Going one way--it reads like... moving up.
(beat)
The other--
(searching)
--they see you throwing something away.

Kelly takes a moment to process. Then, redetermined:

KELLY
How do I reach them?

MARTIN
You can't.

KELLY
But I *have to*. If I just... explain it well enough. If I just say the right words then--

Martin raises his voice, sharply, to shock Kelly, not to scold her.

MARTIN
Kelly!

Kelly freezes.

MARTIN
You can't. Okay? You just can't.
(beat)
They don't think they're wrong.
(beat)
And they've never had to.

We stay with Kelly for a moment.

A5 S4: KITCHEN TABLE

Early morning/dawn through the screen windows.

The scene flashes: "NOVEMBER 2022. BLACK FRIDAY"

Kelly is sitting at the kitchen table with her laptop. She's still wearing the grey t-shirt and sweatpants.

It doesn't look like she's slept.

Rory enters. He's dressed... armed with the BLACK PISTOL in it's holster, bleary eyed with early morning. He moves to the coffee machine.

He stops when he sees Kelly sitting alone at the kitchen table.

RORY
Morning, Kevin. You're up early.

KELLY
Went to sleep early. Woke up early. Jet lag, I guess.

Rory nods.

RORY
I need to walk Laika... but when I get back, maybe you and I get breakfast? Just us. That place you like. Then maybe we go check out some Black Friday sales?

Kelly considers. Not warm. Not cold. Numb. She doesn't look at him.

KELLY
Yeah.
(beat)
Sure.

Rory nods. He grabs Laika's harness, and then puts on a jacket, covering up the BLACK PISTOL and it's holster.

A5 S5: THE TRUCK

They assemble the truck, complete with the cupholder.

The SILVER REVOLVER is barely sticking out. The audience shouldn't see it yet.

Silence. Kelly slumps in the passenger seat. Rory glances at her as he drives. He pulls over and park.

RORY
Say, Kevin, I just quickly want to check in on a gun I ordered. Mind if I leave you in the truck? Five minutes.

KELLY
Sure.

He exits. Heads inside. We stay with Kelly.

Waiting. Too long. Dead air.

Kelly eyes drift down to the cupholder. The one that holds Laika's kibble.

She freezes. Sees the SILVER REVOLVER.

She picks it up. Looks at it. Holds it in both her hands.

She just looks at it for the longest time. Uncomfortably.

She doesn't move. Doesn't even blink.

Her breathing is shallow now.

Stillness.

SPECIAL ON KELLY

Kieran comes by, sadly, solemnly, and hands the microphone to Kelly.

Kelly looks at him.

Kieran looks back, and nods.

Kelly steps forward. Microphone in her right hand. Gun in her left.

She addresses the audience. Slowly.

KELLY
(to Audience)
I know how this sounds.
(beat)
You probably think I'm exaggerating. Or misunderstanding. Or maybe it didn't happen like I remembered it. Or maybe I'm confused.
(beat)
Because I know how this sounds. Especially to Londoners. Surely, I'm not talking about a real gun left in a real cupholder. Surely this is a metaphor for something. That the gun represents some sort of institutionalized violence. Or that I'm talking about Dad being oblivious or--

She stops.

KELLY
No. This happened.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
This isn't a story I'm making up.
(beat)
And it's important to me that you believe me.

Kelly hands the mic back to Kieran.

She sits back down in the passenger side.

Continues to stare at the gun.

Then closes her eyes.

Her hand shakes...

...but she puts it back in the cupholder.

Rory returns, gets in, and starts the truck. Normal.

RORY
Right. Ready for breakfast? Chicken-fried steak again?

Kelly's voice trembles.

KELLY
Dad... you left me with a gun.

RORY
What?
(pause, looks down)
Oh, that? That's nothing. I knew you were in the truck.

KELLY
You left me *alone* with a *loaded gun*.

RORY
...What?

KELLY
Dad... you can't *do* that. I've struggled with depression my whole life. You know that. I'm not safe around guns.

RORY
Sorry. Thought you'd be fine. I knew you were in the truck. Didn't think it'd be a big deal.

Kelly swallows.

KELLY
(shaken)
When we get home... we need to talk about this.

RORY
Sure. We'll talk.
(beat)
Let's get pancakes.

Rory drives.

A5 S6: KELLY'S ROOM

Kelly lies on the bed. Awake. Empty.

Curled up in the fetal position, like she did as a teenager. (Act 1, Scene 11).

Her phone RINGS. She answers it without looking.

KELLY
Kevin O'Connell speaking.

MEGAN (V.O.)
Hey, Kelly. How you holding up?

A pause before Kelly speaks.

KELLY
Aunt Megan?

MEGAN (V.O.)
Who'd you think it was, toots, Rosie O'Donnell?

KELLY
(beat)
There's a surface resemblance.

MEGAN (V.O.)
You know, not to be funny, but sometimes little kids ask me for autographs.

KELLY
What do you tell them?

MEGAN (V.O.)
"There's no crying in baseball."

A chuckle from Kelly, which surprises her.

KELLY
Okay, *that's good*.

MEGAN (V.O.)
Let's get dinner. Mexican. That place that smooshes the avocados in front of you.

Kelly blinks. Starting to re-enter the world.

KELLY
Uh, yeah. Sure. Just you and me?

MEGAN
What, you think I should invite Klansman Greg?

After a small delay... Kelly smiles.

KELLY
I'll get dressed.

A5 S7: MEXICAN RESTAURANT

It's a Mexican restaurant at night. Plates clink. Low restaurant murmur.

Chips and guac are already on the table.

Kelly has changed into the pink dress again, though she still wears the purple camo over it.

Megan sits across from her.

MEGAN
Well, obviously I had to check in with you. Jeezus criminy, what a train wreck. And I owe you an apology.

KELLY
For what? You didn't do anything wrong.

MEGAN
That's just it. I didn't do anything. I should've said something. I was just... shocked. And outnumbered.

KELLY
I get it, though. I should have stood up for myself.

MEGAN
And that priest...

They both shiver in exaggerated horror.

KELLY
Like the Ghost of Thanksgiving Future.

MEGAN
First time I've heard grace start with the last rites.

KELLY
Maybe the turkey was Catholic.

MEGAN
Why not? We've got Holy Guacamole.

KELLY
Christ on a cracker.

MEGAN
The Eucharist of champions.

KELLY
Used to stick'em in the toaster. Make corpus crispies.

They laugh together.

KELLY
You were right, Aunt Megan. I *needed* this.

MEGAN
I figured.
(beat)
Shane wanted to apologize. He thought he said something wrong.

KELLY
Shane? No. He's confused sometimes, but his heart's solid.

MEGAN
(softer)
Hey.

She slides the bowl of guac towards Kelly.

MEGAN
(beat)
Are you going to be okay?

Kelly shrugs. Picks at a chip. Doesn’t eat it.

KELLY
I don't know.

MEGAN
Do you have people in London? Friends who can help you through it?

Kelly doesn't answer verbally. She smiles -- tired, but real.

She looks out at the audience.

Then she looks over to Kieran, who is standing by, offering her the mic.

KELLY
Yeah. I do.

Kelly takes the mic from Kieran.

KELLY
(stage whisper to Kieran)
Thank you.

Megan exits.

Kelly takes off the purple camo, and hands it to Kieran.

The background fades to that of the King of Stars.

A5 S8: KING OF STARS

The background flashes: "DECEMBER 2022. PRESENT DAY"

We no longer need the spotlight on Kelly to distinguish between stand-up and memory, as the flashbacks are over.

KELLY
So, I think I mentioned this before, but I got my degree from Central Texas University. God, I'm glad I didn't come out back then. Being openly trans in Texas is just a good way to get shot. And I don't want any holes drilled in me...
(beat)
Except the one.
(beat)
I hate gun violence. That's why I live in London. I *love* knife crime.
(beat)
If you're used to gun violence? Knife crime is just... *quaint*.
(beat)
You're walking along late at night, a guy jumps out from the bushes with a ski mask and a powdered wig--
(camp, act-out)
"Stand and deliver your coin purse, good madam, lest I gut you, from tickle-gizzard to pleasure-pivot, with yon switching blade!"
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
"Now now now, don't be cheese-pairing me, I want to see every last farthing and ha-penny!"
(beat)
That's what I love. A good old fashioned artisanal mugging.

KELLY
The gun culture in America has my dad refusing to go anywhere without his concealed-carry pistol. Because you never know where the next ninja attack is com--

She stops suddenly.

Frozen.

Breath audible. A panic attack.

Kelly doesn't say these next lines into the microphone.

KELLY
He never carries a revolver.

An awkward beat.

KELLY
Dad said it himself. They're too simple.

Another beat.

KELLY
He said there's "nothing between the thought and the trigger."

Kieran is concerned.

KIERAN
(stage whispering)
Kelly?

Kelly blinks... holds up a hand to Kieran.

KELLY
No. No. I've got this. Thanks.

Kelly takes one last breath, then goes back into performance mode, speaking into the mic.

KELLY
Sorry.
(beat)
That joke just got a lot less funny.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
Anyway--
(gear shift)
--now I'm back in England. Land of the crumpet.
(beat)
You know, before I moved to England, I didn't realize crumpets... were *real*.
(beat)
Like every American, I thought they were a fairy-tale food. So when I saw them I had to try 'em. Took em up to the counter, guy said it would be two quid. Then I asked what I thought was a natural question - how many pounds in a quid?
(beat)
(angry)
Guy told me it was TEN POUNDS to the QUID! Ugh.
(beat)
Naturally, I never went back there. Started shopping at Aldi. There, crumpets are only seven pounds to the quid.

Kieran comes back with the mic stand. Kelly puts it back in the stand.

KELLY
Anyway, I've been Kelly O'Connell, I hope you had as much fun coming out tonight as I have.

Kelly takes a curtsey.

A5 S9: KING OF STARS PUB

Kieran and Kelly sit down at a pub upstairs at the King of Stars.

They both have beers.

They sit in silence for a little bit.

KIERAN
So. I hate to ask, but... near the end. What was that all about?

KELLY
Oh. That.

She takes a swig.

KELLY
My Dad. That gun he left me with. It was a revolver. I thought he just was being careless. He probably *was* just being careless. But he never carries a revolver. What was it even *doing* in the car?

Kelly shakes her head.

KELLY
I'm never going to know for sure. But there's a possibility, bleak as it may seem, that Dad wanted me to become a taste-tester for Smith & Wesson.

KIERAN
Jesus.

A beat.

KIERAN
Although... I hear their flavours are mind blowing.

Kelly breaks, laughing.

KELLY
Jesus, Kieran!

KIERAN
Little worried that might be too much.

KELLY
Nah.
(beat)
Perfect.
(beat)
You gotta laugh, right?

Kelly takes a long sigh.

ASH (20s, gender-nonconforming) approaches. They're wearing a blue blazer and a pink skirt with purple socks.

ASH
Hey, are you Kelly O'Connell?

KELLY
Yes. Hello.

Ash looks around.

ASH
I saw your act. Wanted to come over and talk.

KELLY
Really? You thought it was funny?

ASH
Yeah, I did. Except the sad parts. Kind of a tonal shift. But it got funny at the end again.

KELLY
Yeah, that was what I was going for. I'm not sure if it worked.

ASH
(beat)
I also wanted to say-- thank you. For sharing the story.

KELLY
You're welcome. I used to think I did stand-up as an alternative to therapy. Now I think I do it because it's the one place I can tell my story without getting interrupted or shut down.
(beat)
Food for thought.

Kieran, reading the room, leaves Kelly and Ash alone.

ASH
You said people could ask questions...
(beat)
I think I might be trans. Or... something. I don't know.

Kelly smiles.

KELLY
Well I'll be. An *egg*.

ASH
Yeah.
(pause)
Wait, a what?

KELLY
Don't worry about it. Point is, you're going to be fine. Whatever you decide to do. Whoever you decide to be. Who you are? How you feel?
(beat)
You're not wrong. No matter what anyone tells you.
(beat)
And you've got friends here, if you want them. Found family. Look around. Ash. These are your people.

ASH (O.S.)
I was thinking about coming out to my parents this Christmas.
(beat)
While I'm home from uni.

Kelly's face: absolute alarm.

KELLY
Oh, *fuck* no.

LIGHTS DOWN

IN DARKNESS

We hear a series of voicemail calls from Colleen.

SFX: Beep

COLLEEN (V.O.)
Hey, sweetie. How's the new year going? Everything okay?
(pause)
Haven't heard from you in a while. Things are okay over here. Just wanted to check in. Make sure you're alright. A mother worries, you know. Talk to you later.
(beat)
I love you.

SFX: Beep

COLLEEN (V.O.)
Hey, Kelly. I saw the new stand-up set you put on YouTube. It's even better than the last one. Your birthday's coming up. Wondering if you want us to get you anything.
(beat)
Call me when you get this, okay?
(soft)
Talk to you later.
(beat)
I love you.

SFX: Beep

COLLEEN (V.O.)
Kelly. Can you call me? Just to let me know you're alright?
(beat)
Please?
(beat)
I don't know why you're mad at us.
(beat)
Okay.
(beat)
Okay.
(beat)
We'll be here when you're ready to talk.
(long beat)
I love you.

Silence.

<u>A5 S10: O'CONNELL FAMILY KITCHEN</u>

LIGHTS UP

Shane is combining ingredients into a food processor, talking to himself as he adds them.

Laika watches intently.

SHANE
Okay. One part peanut butter. One part beef broth. Whipped cream.

Shane stakes the whipped cream high.

SHANE
A bit of carob powder.

Shane sprinkles some on.

SHANE
And the garnish.

Shane puts a doggie biscuit into the whipped cream.

SHANE
One pup-puchino coming up for a coffee-consuming canine!

He hands the pup-puchino to Laika.

Laika shoves her face in the whipped cream. Then lovingly licks Shane.

Shane scratches behind Laika's head. Then looks confused.

SHANE
Laika, there's something in your collar.

Shane pulls it out. It's a Monopoly bill. They both look at it.

Behind them, in the backyard, through the window projected on the screen, SASQUATCH casually walks past. He's drinking from a bottle of Hennessy.

Laika's head turns.

Shane doesn't notice.

THE END